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**Spring & Summer
2020**

Left Turn

A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices



Finding Privilege in Quarantine Elaheh Farmand

Kent State and Divided America Ted Morgan

Transnational Feminist Activism Rachel O'Donnell

The Bonus Army Protest Gary Olson

"U.S. Crimes Don't Matter" Faramarz Farbod

Popular Sovereignty Stephen Eric Bronner

We Are All Jakarta A Review by David Swanson

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Notes from the Editor

“Everything Hurts”

“I’m claustrophobic, my stomach hurt, my neck hurts, everything hurts, some water or something, please, please, I can’t breathe officer, don’t kill me.” These were some of the last words uttered in desperation by George Perry Floyd Jr before he was pronounced dead as officer Derek Chauvin knelt on his neck for nearly eight minutes. Since then millions of people in the U.S. and around the world have poured into streets of large and small cities alike protesting racist police violence and systemic racism. Hundreds of thousands of protesters since have directly experienced the blatant disregard for their lives and rights by police and state violence targeting them. This cannot but have a profound effect on the people protesting and the millions witnessing the unfolding events. It was not long ago when many people worried the end of Sanders’s electoral campaign would lead to cynicism and withdrawal from political activism by the young who had flocked to the Senator’s campaign. Well, no more. Our hope is that a lasting critical consciousness will emerge out of the clarity that these events are bound to impart to those experiencing them directly and to those witnessing them. A critical consciousness that can see the connections between police violence, the prison-industrial complex, institutional racism, the surveillance state, class warfare, the rule of capital, ecological destruction, imperialism (because All Black Lives Matter globally), and of course a dysfunctional political system whose ruling elites are split between those who prefer responding with more state violence, feverish and unhinged talk of Antifa, anarchists, rioters and communist-led violence in the streets, and those who at best would like to co-opt the protests and offer status-quo-friendly-reforms all the while ignoring or dismissing the just demands of the protesters.

Good and Bad Lootings and Riots

Let’s not be fooled by the ruling politician’s rhetoric about the threat of Antifa, riots in the streets, how much they value peaceful protesting, and how much they care about the lives of all black people and all lives too.

In his phone call with governors, President Trump asked that state law enforcement “dominate streets” and “knock out” the “anarchists,” “terrorists,” and “radical left” protesters “so fast like they’re bowling pins.” He called for “5- or 10-year jail terms and repeatedly referred to the coordinated state suppression of the 2011 Occupy Wall Street movement as a model for state behavior today and said that these troublesome protesters are like or are the same ones from that movement. (And, no, Trump didn’t give credit to Obama for suppressing Occupy.) Earlier he had tweeted that he will designate Antifa as a terrorist organization.

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Police are the Enemy Within

MICHAEL D. YATES

In 2017, Daniel Fetonte was elected to the National Political Committee of the Democratic Socialists of America (DSA), a rapidly growing left-wing organization in the United States. Fetonte was co-chair of the Austin, Texas, branch of the DSA and had been involved in labor union organizing for many years. However, he had also been employed by the Combined Law Enforcement Associations of Texas, the largest police union in the state, with a membership of 21,000 police officers. When DSA members learned of this, many raised objections, arguing that anyone representing cops, who are the perpetrators of assaults, including numerous murders, on working people, especially if they are black, should not be an officer in an organization such as the DSA. (*Can the Working Class Change the World?*)

Fetonte was eventually forced to resign. Today, with police murders and assaults on people of color leading to worldwide protests, cops are assaulting old men, news reporters, legal observers, putting out people’s eyes with plastic bullets, spreading teargas near and far, and jailing thousands in crowded cells, denying them habeas corpus, it is difficult to believe that there was debate in DSA about Fetonte. Police are doing these deeds in full view of television cameras and smartphone videos. If it never before occurred to many of us, doesn’t it now seem obvious to every thinking person that police are not workers, not members of the working class? They are, instead, the enemy of those who labor.

We say, “Law Enforcement.” What does that mean? A look at history tells us that the laws have always had extreme bias built into them. In the United States, the Constitution itself, embraced slavery. So, enforcing the law meant enforcing slavery. On the ground, applying the law meant it was fine to beat and torture human beings, because the law considered them property, to be done with as the slaveowner saw fit. If slaves escaped, public and private “police” were free to capture them, even kill them if necessary, though it was expected that property be returned intact (and the owner might punish or kill the slave catcher failed to do so). After the Civil War, there was a brief period of federal government protection of former slaves, but this ended in 1877, and there followed a century of legally sanctioned violence, including innumerable lynchings of black men and women. There also followed mass incarceration, with prisoners farmed out to businesses in what amounted to a new form of slavery, one that continues today with the incredible rise in imprisonment of black persons, what Michelle Alexander calls the “New Jim Crow.”

The last paragraph could be rewritten with Indigenous Peoples or Mexican Americans substituted for Black Americans. They have been continuous victims of police violence. American Indians were slaughtered by the U.S. Army and are today routinely subjected to police barbarity. Throughout the Southwest, Mexican Americans were hanged by mobs and otherwise treated with extreme cruelty, without

recourse to police protection. Today, the U.S. government is holding Hispanic immigrant children in concentration camps.

The law is also biased in favor of property over persons. Ownership of businesses, buildings, machinery, and so forth enjoys all manner of legal protection, exactly what we would expect in a capitalist system. Urban police forces were originally established to quell disturbances by city workers protesting working conditions and merchants raising prices of bread and other essential products above their traditional levels. Similarly, national guards and their ubiquitous armories were put in place or greatly expanded in response to the great labor uprising in 1877. Their job was (and is) to protect business property from damage. Harm to people is simply collateral damage, the fault of those who had the temerity to rise up in the first place.

Even the labor laws, which presumably give workers collective rights, go out of their way to protect employer property from boycotts, strikes, and pickets. What is more, police and even the U.S. Army have been regularly deployed to break strikes, using force and murder when necessary. Prosecutions for such behavior have been extremely rare.

Today, police have organized themselves into powerful unions. And they have been aided and abetted by U.S. organized labor. Consider this, taken from an essay I am writing, especially next time you imagine that the U.S. labor movement, as currently constituted, can transform itself and suddenly become a force for the liberation of the working class: Both the AFL-CIO and national unions have chartered police union locals. What is more, police unions routinely negotiate collective bargaining agreements that make it nearly impossible to severely discipline cops who maim or even kill working people, especially if they are people of color. Town and city government officials are typically in league with the police unions, receiving large donations from them and usually serving the same rich constituents. Recently, The Center for Public Integrity sought comments from top union leaders concerning police violence and police unions. Its reporter wrote: “None were willing to talk about police unions. Trumka, of the AFL-CIO, was too busy to chat. The president of the United Food and Commercial Workers Union couldn’t fit a call into his schedule. Teamsters President James Hoffa declined to comment.

Silence from the Service Employees International Union, the American Federation of State, County and Municipal Employees, United Auto Workers, Communication Workers of America, Unite Here and the American Federation of Teachers.

Labor leaders briefly talked about police unions in response to a reporter’s question Wednesday. They seemed uncomfortable.

Randi Weingarten, president of the American Federation of Teachers, said no union contracts should shield employee misconduct, but that focusing on collective bargaining is a ‘false choice.’”

In the wake of the police murder of Michael Brown in Ferguson, Missouri, Trumka made this remarkable statement: “Lesley McSpadden, Michael Brown’s mother who works in a grocery store, is our sister, an AFL-CIO union member, and Darren Wilson, the officer who killed Michael Brown, is a union member, too, and he is our brother.”

We cannot prevent cops from having their own organizations. But we can demand that they not be given sanction by our labor spokespersons and their unions. We can demand that police be outside the purview of labor laws meant to protect workers, not murderers and torturers (not too strong a word for the notorious Chicago Police Department and many others). Because make no mistake about it, the police are our enemy. We must have entirely different conceptions of public safety, as well as prisons and justice. The more radical our demands, the better. We live in a sick, depraved system. Destroy it root and branch, as we learn to care for ourselves, collectively and democratically. We owe this, at the least, to the memory of the myriad struggles of Black, Hispanic, Native American, and all the workers who fought so bravely to turn the tide against police brutality and the depredations that are the daily lives of all who live under capital’s yoke.

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This essay originally appeared in Counterpunch on June 12, 2020.

“For two decades, Chicago police routinely tortured suspects. They “beat suspects with telephone books, flashlights, batons, and baseball bats. Some victims described being burned, either by their flesh pressed against hot radiators or by having cigarettes put out on their bare skin. Some were nearly suffocated with plastic typewriter covers. Other torture survivors reported having guns put to their head or in their mouth, and being struck with cattle prods.”

— Kelly Hayes, The Appeal, Dec. 6, 2019.

10 Reasons Why Defunding Police Should Lead to Defunding War

MEDEA BENJAMIN & ZOLTAN GROSSMAN

Since George Floyd was murdered, we have seen an increasing convergence of the “war at home” against Black and brown people with the “wars abroad” that the U.S. has waged against people in other countries. Army and National Guard troops have been deployed in U.S. cities, as militarized police treat our cities as occupied war zones. In response to this “endless war” at home, the growing and thunderous cries for defunding the police have been echoed by calls for defunding the Pentagon’s wars. Instead of seeing these as two separate but related demands, we should see them as intimately linked, since the racialized police violence on our streets and the racialized violence the U.S. has long inflicted on people around the world are mirror reflections of each other.

We can learn more about the war at home by studying the wars abroad, and learn more about the wars abroad by studying the war at home. Here are some of those connections:

- 1. The U.S. kills people of color at home and abroad.** The United States was founded on the ideology of white supremacy, from the genocide against Native Americans to upholding the system of slavery. U.S. police kill about 1,000 people per year, [disproportionately in the Black community and other communities of color](#). U.S. foreign policy is similarly based on the white superiority-derived concept of “American exceptionalism,” in tandem with European partners. The [endless series of wars the U.S. military has fought abroad](#) would not be possible without a [view of the world that dehumanizes foreign peoples](#). “If you want to bomb or invade a foreign country filled with black- or brown-skinned people, as the United States military so often does, you have to first demonize those people, dehumanize them, suggest they’re backward people in need of saving or savage people in need of killing,” [said journalist Mehdi Hasan](#). The U.S. military has been responsible for the deaths of [many hundreds of thousands](#) of Black and brown people around the world, and the denial of their rights to national self-determination. The double standard that sanctifies the lives of U.S. troops and citizens, but disregards the people whose countries the Pentagon and its allies destroy is as hypocritical as the one that values white lives over Black and brown lives at home.
- 2. Just as the U.S. was created by taking over the lands of Indigenous peoples by force, so America as an empire uses war to expand access to markets and resources.** Settler colonialism has been an “endless war” at home against Indigenous nations, who were colonized when their lands were still defined as foreign territories, to be annexed for their fertile land and natural resources. The Army forts stationed in Native nations back then were the equivalent of foreign military bases today, and the Native resisters were the original “insurgents” who were in the way of American conquest. The “Manifest Destiny”

colonization of Native lands [morphed into overseas imperial expansion](#), including the seizure of Hawai’i, Puerto Rico, and other colonies, and the counterinsurgency wars in the Philippines and Vietnam. In the 21st century, U.S.-led wars have destabilized the Middle East and Central Asia, while increasing control over the region’s fossil fuel resources. The Pentagon has [used the template of the Indian Wars](#) to frighten the American public with the specter of “lawless tribal regions” that need to be “tamed,” within countries such as Iraq, Afghanistan, Yemen, and Somalia. Meanwhile, Wounded Knee in 1873 and Standing Rock in 2016 show how settler colonialism can become remilitarized back in the U.S. “homeland.” Stopping oil pipelines and toppling Columbus statues shows how Indigenous resistance can also be renewed in the heart of the empire.

- 3. The police and military are both internally plagued by racism.** With the Black Lives Matter protests, many people have now learned about the origins of U.S. police in all-white slave patrols. It is no accident that hiring and promotion within police departments have historically favored whites, and officers of color around the country continue to sue their departments for discriminatory practices. The same is true in the military, where segregation was official policy until 1948. Today, people of color are pursued to fill the bottom ranks, but not the top positions. Military recruiters set up recruiting stations in communities of color, where government disinvestment in social services and education makes the military one of the few ways to not only get a job, but access to health care and a free college education. That’s why about [43 percent of the 1.3 million men and women on active duty are people of color](#), and Native Americans serve in the Armed Forces at [five times](#) the national average. But the upper echelons of the military remain almost exclusively a white-boys’ club (of the 41 senior commanders, only [two are Black](#) and only one is a woman). Under Trump, racism in the military is on the rise. A 2019 survey found that 53 percent of service members of color said they had seen examples of white nationalism or ideologically driven racism among their fellow troops, a number up significantly from the same poll in 2018. Far-right militias have attempted to both [infiltrate the military](#) and [collude with police](#).
- 4. The Pentagon’s troops and “surplus” weapons are being used on our streets.** Just as the Pentagon often uses the language of “police actions” to describe its foreign interventions, police are being militarized within the U.S. When the Pentagon ended up in the 1990s with weapons of war it no longer needed, it created the “1033 Program” to distribute armored personnel carriers, submachine guns, and even grenade launchers to police departments. More than [\\$7.4 billion](#) in military equipment and goods have been transferred to more than 8,000 law enforcement agencies—turning the police into occupation forces and our cities into war zones. We saw this vividly in 2014 in the aftermath of the killing of Michael Brown, when police flush with military gear made the streets of Ferguson, Missouri look like Iraq. More recently, we saw these militarized police forces deployed against the George Floyd Rebellion, with [military helicopters](#) overhead, and the Minnesota Governor comparing the deployment to an “overseas war.” Trump has [deployed federal troops](#) and wanted to send in more, much as active-duty troops were previously used against several workers’ strikes in the

1890s–1920s, the Bonus Army veterans’ protests of 1932, and Black uprisings in Detroit in 1943 and 1967, in multiple cities in 1968 (after the assassination of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.), and in Los Angeles in 1992 (after the acquittal of the police who had beaten Rodney King). Sending in soldiers trained for combat only makes a bad situation worse, and this can open the eyes of Americans to the shocking violence with which the U.S. military tries, but often fails, to quell dissent in occupied countries. Congress may now object to [the transfer of military equipment](#) to police, and [Pentagon officials may object](#) to using troops against U.S. citizens at home, but they rarely object when the targets are foreigners or [even U.S. citizens who live abroad](#).

5. U.S. interventions abroad, especially the “War on Terror,” erode our civil liberties at home. Techniques of surveillance that are tested on foreigners have [long been imported to suppress dissent at home](#), ever since occupations in Latin America and the Philippines. In the wake of the 9/11 attacks, while the U.S. military was purchasing super drones to kill U.S. enemies (and often innocent civilians) and collect intelligence on entire cities, U.S. police departments began buying smaller, but powerful, spy drones. Black Lives Matter protesters have recently seen these [“eyes in the sky” spying on them](#). This is just one example of the surveillance society that the U.S. has become since 9/11. The so-called “War on Terror” has been a justification for the tremendous expansion of government powers at home—broad “data mining,” increased the secrecy of federal agencies, No-Fly lists to prohibit people tens of thousands of people from traveling, and vast government spying on social, religious and political groups, from the Quakers to Greenpeace to the ACLU, including [military spying on antiwar groups](#). The use of unaccountable mercenaries abroad also makes their use more likely at home, as when Blackwater private security contractors were [flown from Baghdad to New Orleans](#) in the wake of Hurricane Katrina in 2005, to be used against the devastated Black community. And in turn, if police and armed far-right militias and mercenaries can commit violence with impunity in the homeland, it normalizes and enables even great violence elsewhere.

6. The xenophobia and Islamophobia at the heart of the “War on Terror” has fed hatred of immigrants and Muslims at home. Just as wars abroad are justified by racism and religious bias, they also feed white and Christian supremacy at home, as could be seen in Japanese-American incarceration in the 1940s, and anti-Muslim sentiment that rose in the 1980s. The 9/11 attacks precipitated hate crimes against Muslims and Sikhs, as well as a federally imposed travel ban that denies entrance to the U.S. for people from entire countries, separating families, depriving students of access to universities, and detaining immigrants in private prisons. Senator Bernie Sanders, [writing in Foreign Affairs](#), said, “When our elected leaders, pundits, and cable news personalities promote relentless fear-mongering about Muslim terrorists, they inevitably create a climate of fear and suspicion around Muslim American citizens—a climate in which demagogues like Trump can thrive.” He also decried the xenophobia resulting from turning our immigration debate into a debate about Americans’ personal security, pitting millions of U.S. citizens against undocumented and even doc-

umented immigrants. The [militarization of the U.S.-Mexico border](#), using hyperbolic claims of infiltrating criminals and terrorists, has normalized the use of drones and checkpoints that bring the techniques of authoritarian control into the “homeland.” (Meanwhile, U.S. Customs and Border Protection personnel were also [deployed to the borders of occupied Iraq](#).)

7. Both the military and the police suck up enormous amounts of taxpayer dollars that should be used for building a just, sustainable, and equitable society. Americans are already participating in supporting state violence, whether we realize it or not, by paying taxes to the police and military that carry it out in our names. Police budgets account for an astronomical percentage of cities’ discretionary funds compared to other crucial community programs, [ranging from 20 to 45 percent](#) of discretionary funding in major metropolitan areas. Per capita police spending in the city of Baltimore for 2020 is an astounding \$904 (imagine what every resident could do with \$904). Nationwide, the U.S. spends more than twice as much on “law and order” as it does on cash welfare programs. This trend has been widening since the 1980s, as we have taken funds out of poverty programs to put into fighting crime, the inevitable consequence of that neglect. The same pattern is true with the Pentagon budget. The 2020 military budget of \$738 billion is larger than the next ten countries combined. The *Washington Post* [reported](#) that if the U.S. spent the same proportion of its GDP on its military as most European countries do, it “could fund a universal child-care policy, extend health insurance to the approximately 30 million Americans who lack it, or provide substantial investments in repairing the nation’s infrastructure.” [Closing the 800+ overseas military bases alone](#) would save \$100 billion dollars a year. Prioritizing the police and military means deprioritizing resources for community needs. Even President Eisenhower described military spending in 1953 as “a theft from those who hunger and are not fed.”

8. Repressive techniques used abroad inevitably come home. Soldiers are trained to see most of the civilians they encounter abroad as a potential threat. When they return from Iraq or Afghanistan, they discover that one of the few employers that give priority to vets are police departments and security companies. They also offer relatively [high salaries, good benefits, and union protections](#), which is why [one in five](#) police officers is a veteran. So, even soldiers who come home with PTSD or drug and alcohol abuse, instead of being adequately cared for, are given weapons and put out on the streets. No wonder studies show that police with military experience, especially those who have deployed overseas, are significantly more likely to be involved in shooting incidents than those with no military service. The same relationship of repression at home and abroad is true of torture techniques, which were taught to militaries and police throughout Latin America during the Cold War. They were also used on Afghans at the U.S.-run Bagram Air Base prison, and on Iraqis at the Abu Ghraib prison, where one of the torturers had practiced similar techniques as a [prison guard in Pennsylvania](#). The purpose of [waterboarding](#), a torture technique stretching back to counterinsurgency wars in Native America and the Philippines, is to prevent a person from breathing, much like the police chokehold that killed Eric Garner or the knee

to the neck that killed George Floyd. #ICantBreathe is not only a statement for change at home, but also a statement with global implications

9. The War on Drugs has put more money into the police and military but has been devastating to people of color, at home and abroad.

The so-called “War on Drugs” has devastated communities of color, particularly the Black community, leading to catastrophic levels of gun violence and mass incarceration. People of color are more likely to be stopped, searched, arrested, convicted, and harshly sentenced for drug-related offenses. Nearly 80 percent of people in federal prison and almost 60 percent of people in state prison for drug offenses are Black or Latinx. The War on Drugs has also devastated communities overseas. Throughout South America, the Caribbean, and Afghanistan in both drug production and trafficking areas, U.S.-supported wars have only empowered organized crime and drug cartels, leading to an [upsurge of violence](#), corruption, impunity, erosion of rule of law, and massive human rights violations. Central America is now home to some of the world’s most [dangerous cities](#), leading to the mass migration to the U.S. that Donald Trump has weaponized for political purposes. Just as police responses at home do not solve social problems that stem from poverty and despair (and often create more harm than good), military deployments abroad do not resolve historical conflicts that usually have their roots in social and economic inequalities, and instead create a cycle of violence that worsens the crisis

10. Lobbying machines solidify support for police and war industry funding.

Law enforcement lobbies have long built support for police and prisons among state and federal politicians, using a fear of crime, and a desire for the profits and jobs that are funneled to its backers. Among the strongest backers are police and prison guard unions, which instead of using the labor movement to defend the powerless against the powerful, defend their members against community complaints of brutality. The military-industrial complex similarly uses its lobbying muscle to keep politicians compliant with its wishes. Every year billions of dollars are funneled from U.S. taxpayers to hundreds of arms corporations, who then wage lobbying campaigns pushing for even more foreign military aid and weapons sales. They [spend \\$125 million a year](#) on lobbying, and another \$25 million a year on donating to political campaigns. Manufacturing weapons has provided millions of workers with some of the nation’s highest industrial wages, and many of their unions (such as the [Machinists](#)) are part of the Pentagon lobby. These lobbies for the military contractors have become more powerful and influential not only over the budget but also over the creation of U.S. foreign policy. The power of the military-industrial complex has become far more dangerous than even President Eisenhower himself feared when he warned the nation, in 1961, against its undue influence.

Both “defunding the police” and “defunding war,” while opposed by most elected Republicans and mainstream Democrats, are gaining public support. Mainstream politicians have long been afraid of being painted as “soft on crime” or as “soft on defense.” This self-perpetuating ideology reproduces the idea that the U.S. needs more police on the streets and more troops policing the world, or else chaos will reign.

The mainstream media has kept politicians afraid to offer any kind of alternate, less militaristic vision. But the recent uprisings have turned “Defund the Police” from a fringe chant to a national conversation, and some cities are already reallocating millions of dollars from the police to community programs.

Likewise, until recently, calling for cuts to U.S. military expenditure was a great taboo in Washington D.C. Year after year, all but a few Democrats lined up with Republicans to vote for massive increases in military spending. But that is now beginning to change. Congresswoman Barbara Lee introduced an historic, aspirational [resolution](#) proposing massive \$350 billion in cuts, which is over 40 percent of the Pentagon budget. And Sen. Bernie Sanders, along with other progressives, introduced [an amendment](#) to the National Defense Authorization Act to cut the Pentagon budget by 10 percent.

Just as we want to radically redefine the role of police in our local communities, so we must radically redefine the role of military personnel in the global community. As we chant “Black Lives Matter,” we should also remember the lives of people dying every day from U.S. bombs in Yemen and Afghanistan, U.S. sanctions in Venezuela and Iran, and U.S. weapons in Palestine and the Philippines. The killing of Black Americans rightly elicits masses of protesters, which can help open a window of awareness about the [hundreds of thousands](#) of non-American lives taken in U.S. military campaigns. As the platform of the Movement for Black Lives platform [says](#): “Our movement must be tied to liberation movements around the world.”

Those who are now questioning an [increasingly militarized](#) approach to law enforcement should also question a militarized approach to foreign relations. Much as unaccountable police in riot gear are a danger to our communities, so, too, an unaccountable military, armed to the teeth and functioning largely in secret, is a danger to the world. During his iconic anti-imperialist speech, “Beyond Vietnam,” Dr. King famously said: “I could never again raise my voice against the violence of the oppressed in the ghettos without having first spoken clearly to the greatest purveyor of violence in the world today: my own government.”

The protests to “Defund the Police” have compelled Americans to see beyond police reform to a radical reconceiving of public safety. So, too, we need a radical reconceiving of our national security in the slogan “Defund War.” If we find indiscriminate state violence in our streets appalling, we should feel similarly about state violence abroad, and call for divesting from both police and the Pentagon, and reinvesting those taxpayer dollars to rebuild communities at home and abroad.

This article originally appeared in Common Dreams on July, 14, 2020.

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The Bonus Army Protest

GARY OLSON

July 28 will mark almost the 90th anniversary of one of most controversial protests in U.S. history and yet it remains virtually unknown to most Americans. On that day, in 1932, 500 U.S. army infantrymen with loaded rifles, fixed bayonets and gas grenades containing a vomit inducing ingredient, 200 cavalries, a machine gun squadron, 800 police and 6 M1917 army tanks, prepared to attack 17,000 unarmed men, plus thousands of their wives and children. Moments before the assault, Gen. Douglas MacArthur, in charge of the operation, turned to a police official standing next to him and said, “I will break the back of the enemy.”

The attack was ordered by President Herbert Hoover and commanded by Gen. MacArthur. Dwight D. Eisenhower was MacArthur’s aide and Major George S. Patton led the tank unit. After donning gas masks, the army tossed hundreds of tear-gas grenades into the encampment which started raging fires and the assault drove all the bedraggled occupants from the area. The encampment was then burned to the ground.

This wasn’t Cuba, the Philippines or the Mexican border — but in Washington, D.C. The camp, nicknamed “Hooverville,” occupied by WWI veterans who were living in tents and shanties others living in crumbling government buildings along Pennsylvania Avenue near the capital. If your education was anything like mine, there wasn’t any mention of this event in any history class.

Some 4 million vets had returned from the war and found that others had taken their jobs at a considerably higher wage than the \$1 per day soldier’s pay and expected more help from their government. Presidents Wilson, Harding and Coolidge each firmly opposed making any to payments to the mostly unemployed vets, with Coolidge stating that “Patriotism, bought and paid for, is not patriotism.” In 1924, Congress kicked the can down the road by promising a bonus payment of \$1.25 for each day of overseas service and \$1.00 for every day of home service. There would be a limit of \$625 for overseas service and \$500 for home service. But Catch-22 was that it could not be redeemed until 1945. The vets quickly dubbed it the “Tombstone Bonus” because many of them would be dead before collecting.

With the Great Depression deepening, demands for making an immediate payment were escalating. Finally, a bill was passed but President Hoover vetoed it. In response, some 300 veterans, led by ex-sergeant Walter Waters boarded a freight train in Portland, Oregon in early May, 1932, and headed for Washington, DC. Soon, others began their pilgrimage to the Capital from across the country in dilapidated buses, overcrowded pick-up trucks, walking and hitchhiking. The vets and their families were in desperate financial shape with overdue bills to pay, hungry and with evictions hanging over their heads. They demanded immediate payment of the bonus.

Calling themselves the Bonus Expeditionary Forces (BEF) and soon known as the “Bonus Army,” between 17,00 and 25,000 trekkers began arriving on May 23, 1932. Assuming their demands wouldn’t be met any time soon, they proceeded

to set up a long-term presence. In orderly fashion, they mapped out streets named for states, set up a library, the “B.E.F. Post Office, barbershop, military-style sanitation, appointed M.P.s to keep order, published their own camp newspaper and even organized evening vaudeville shows. Some ten thousand other vets occupied partially-demolished government buildings on a stretch between the Capitol and the White House. Extremely patriotic, the vets insisted that an American flag fly over every tent and shanty.

Further, as Roy Wilkins, then a young reporter with a press pass, wrote, “There was only one absentee in the camp: James Crow.” The entire, massive undertaking was one in which Blacks and whites shared everything together. During WWI, the military was still segregated as was Anacostia Park when the marchers arrived. The vets who had fought a war together deliberately decided to live side-by-side and set up in the “black” section of the park. This fact alone may have led some people fear the movement. General MacArthur’s “most trusted subordinate” Brig. Gen. George Van Horn Moseley portrayed black and white veterans living together as “proof that Negroes and Jewish Communists were planning a revolution.” In truth, radicals and communists were dismissed by the BEF and were never a serious element in the movement.

As noted American historian Howard Zinn wrote, “In the 1930s, America was in a state of near-revolution, something that very much worried the people in Washington.” The vets were labeled “Red Agitators” and Gen. MacArthur declared that the marchers were “.. traitors bent on overthrowing the government — pacifists and its bedfellow communism are all around us.” The Army’s Military Intelligence Division thought that Communists were deeply involved in the efforts and J. Edgar Hoover, the new FBI director, was intent on proving that the Bonus Army was inspired by reds. Fitting then, that in instructing his troops on the possible use of force during the assault, Maj. Patton advised that “Large numbers of casualties will become an object lesson.”

Historians agree that 1932 was “cruellest year” of the Great Depression and on June 25, 1932 the U.S. House of Representatives passed a compensation bill but it was defeated in the Senate by a vote of 62-18. By July, General MacArthur and Secretary of War, Patrick Hurley were anticipating violence, not just in the Capital but especially in the slums of dozens of major cities. Over the preceding two months, MacArthur had been secretly training special army units in “riot control.” Interestingly, the Marine Corps was not involved in these activities and in an Army intelligence report, not declassified until 1991, we learned that it was feared the Marines were unreliable because they might side with the Bonus marchers. Apropos to this concern, Marine Corps Gen. Smedley Butler, the most decorated Marine in the history of the Marine Corps, had visited the encampment and told the vets: I never saw such Americana as is exhibited by you people. You have just as much right to have a lobby here as any steel corporation. Makes me so damn mad, a whole lot of people speak of you as tramps. By God, they didn’t speak of you as tramps in 1917 and ‘18.

In November, Gov. Franklin D. Roosevelt was elected president. Although he also opposed the bonus, after the assault he said, “This will elect me.” It’s interesting to speculate what might have occurred had the Bonus Army still been there after FDR’s inauguration. Wouldn’t any president have acted in similar fashion to Hoover?

In 1933, FDR sliced \$480 million from veterans' benefits including reducing disability payments by 25 percent (20 percent of the marchers were disabled) "to balance the budget." In 1936, the legislature passed another bonus bill but again FDR vetoed it, arguing it wouldn't be "fiscally prudent." Convinced that his New Deal efforts had saved capitalism from socialism, Roosevelt returned to being a conventional politician advocating for balanced budgets. This time, both the Senate (76-19) and the House (324-61) overrode his veto and the vets received \$583 on average. Some jobs went their way under the New Deal's Civilian Conservation Corps and 700 worked in so-called "Veterans' Rehabilitation Camps" in Florida. In the end, some 45,000 BEF members had passed through Washington before scattering across the country to join millions of others during the depths of the Great Depression.

I'm not an historian but one lesson that occurs to me is that this episode, which has been relegated to the dustbin of U.S. history, is the critical role of mass protest in achieving even a modicum of justice. For example, the Bonus Army's march and its aftermath was a major factor contributing to the passage of the G.I. Bill — something else omitted from my history textbooks. With millions of vets returning from WWII, politicians could not be unmindful of what occurred in 1932. Paul Dickson and Thomas B. Allen, two eminent scholars on the era remind us of the primary motive behind the eventual passage of the bill: Beneath all of this was the very real fear the nation would pay for lack of a comprehensive plan to help veterans by facing a much larger and more hostile version of the Bonus Army. Representative Hamilton Fish Jr., now a political foe of Roosevelt agreed that veterans could not come home and sell apples as they did after the last war, because if that is all they are offered, I believe we would have chaotic and revolutionary conditions in America.

Experts working for the American Legion, not the Congress, drafted a rough version of what eventually became law. Opponents included leaders of elite colleges who feared that working-class men and women would lower the educational standards of their institutions. Robert Hutchins, president of the University of Chicago, predicted that American colleges and universities "will find themselves converted into educational hobo jungles." Southern politicians were dismayed that millions of Black vets would be given \$20 per week, thus undermining the wage system in the Deep South.

The Senate passed the bill 50-0 and it passed the House, 387-0 because the \$20 per week provision was stripped from the original version. After more intense wrangling which cast doubt on the bill being passed at all, the powerful American Legion Lobby brought intense pressure on opponents. Finally, FDR set aside his opposition to "special privileges" for vets and signed the G.I. Bill on June 22, 1944 — with the \$20 per week wage intact. Some 12 million vets took advantage of it. (Note: My father was one of them).

It's no wonder that Dr. Martin Luther King and his advisers studied the Bonus Army's tactics for inspiration in preparing their own multiracial Poor People's Campaign events in Washington, D.C. during the Spring of 1968, just weeks after King's assassination. Another important lesson from the Bonus Army marchers was, "If you have a grievance, take it to Washington, and if you want to be heard, take a lot of people with you."

Finally, today we have a confluence of factors, including the capitalist state's failure to protect its citizens from the Covid pandemic, looming fiscal austerity in the face of another Great Depression and newly transparent institutional racism, has provided an unparalleled opportunity to replicate the Bonus Army's action in the nation's capital, this time on a hitherto unprecedented scale, depth and breadth of demands.

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Kent State and Divided America: 50 Years Later

TED MORGAN

“The past is never dead. It’s not even past. —William Faulkner

For some of us, the killing of four students at Kent State on Monday, May 4, 1970 is a moment we will never forget. It was certainly one of the iconic moments of 1960s-era protests, immortalized in Neil Young’s “Ohio,” with its refrain, “four dead in Ohio.”

Students on campuses across the nation erupted in furious, and occasionally violent protest after President Nixon announced on April 30 that American forces in Vietnam had invaded neutral Cambodia. In effect, Nixon acknowledged that he had previously lied to the public. Students on the fairly conservative Kent State campus began protesting peacefully on May 1, but later that night young people frequenting the town’s bars began to disrupt traffic and eventually, amidst a police crackdown, smashed store windows. Tensions grew the next day, and that night the ROTC building on campus was burned. Police and National Guard troops drove students into their dorms.

Tensions escalated on May 3 with armed National Guard troops occupying the campus and Ohio governor James Rhodes declaring the students were “worse than the Brown Shirt and communist elements.” That evening students gathered to protest the Guard’s presence on campus, a rally broken up by tear gas.

Despite the presence of armed Guardsmen throughout the campus, about two thousand students gathered for a previously-scheduled rally at noon on May 4, and their numbers grew when nearby classes ended. Although ordered to disperse, and later tear gassed, most students, believing their campus had been invaded, remained. With fixed bayonets and loaded rifles, the Guard advanced on the students, launching more tear gas. Many students retreated, and a standoff resulted, with in most cases about a hundred yards apart separating the two; Guardsmen launched tear gas canisters at the students who, in turn, reviled the Guard with abusive language, while some threw rocks. Few if any imagined the Guards’ rifles were locked and loaded, as they were.

Within thirty minutes of the noontime start, a line of Guardsmen suddenly turned to face the students, dropped to their knees, and opened fire. Four students were killed, only two of whom were protesting, and nine were wounded, one permanently paralyzed. Most of those hit were a hundred yards or more from the soldiers.

News reports and John Filo’s iconic photograph brought the shocking news to a stunned nation. In typical fashion the Nixon White House issued a statement blaming the students, “when dissent turns to violence, it invites tragedy,” and Vice President Spiro Agnew denounced the “psychotic and criminal elements in our society.” Well over a thousand campuses exploded in student protest, leading to a student strike and 536 campuses shutting down completely, 51 for the remainder of the school year. Ten

days after the Kent State shootings, two black students at Jackson State College in Mississippi were killed and twelve were wounded when police opened fire on a women’s dormitory during protests against the Cambodian invasion. The Jackson State killings received far less media coverage.

Other Americans echoed the rhetoric of politicians like Agnew and Governor Rhodes, nowhere more than in Kent, Ohio. For weeks, the local paper printed a full page of letters revealing sentiments like “Live ammunition! Well, really, what did they expect, spitballs?” “Hooray! I shout for God and Country ... America, support it, or leave it.” A prominent local attorney noted that if he were faced with the situation and had a submachine gun, “there probably would have been 140 of them dead, and that’s what they need.” One non-protesting student returned home to hear her mother pronounce ““It would have been better for America if every student on that hill had been killed.” “Mother!” she replied, “I was there. Only a miracle of some kind saved me. What about that?” To which her mother responded, “You would have deserved it.”

After its thorough investigation of the Kent State history, the President’s Commission on Campus Unrest observed that, regardless of “intolerable” acts of student violence over the weekend, the “indiscriminate firing of rifles into a crowd of students and the deaths that followed were unnecessary, unwarranted, and inexcusable.” More generally, the Commission declared: The crisis on American campuses has no parallel in the history of the nation. This crisis has roots in divisions of American society as deep as any since the Civil War. The divisions are reflected in violent acts and harsh rhetoric, and in the enmity of those Americans who see themselves as occupying enemy camps.

That last line may sound familiar to contemporary readers, even if the events of 50 or more years ago don’t. It’s hard to convey to younger Americans the daily horror that was the American war in Vietnam. Antiwar protest first erupted in the wake of Lyndon Johnson’s 1965 escalation of the war, and expanded enormously in subsequent years, spreading across the nation, with increasingly confrontational, and in some cases violent, tactics. By 1970, a majority of Americans opposed the war, and a year later a majority felt the war was “immoral” —a percentage that would rise significantly in later years.

Indeed, the *roots of today’s polarization* reside in what happened in the 1960s era. Careful scrutiny of media and movement accounts reveals a telling pattern —from civil rights to black power, free speech to campus liberation, as well as the antiwar and women’s liberation movements. Each movement in its own way reflected underlying democratic urges —the empowerment of people fundamentally marginalized in American society, the quest for respect for one’s personhood, the desire for an American foreign policy that respected the self-determination of other peoples, etc. At some level, all fundamentally posed a challenge to existing American institutions.

It was to this latter, more radical aspect that the mass media were stone deaf. Media discourse ranged between liberal and conservative insiders telling us what the protests meant. The media routinely viewed protests with suspicion, often belittling if not outright condemning them; images of the most flamboyant behaviors — often the more violent or bizarre actions of a few —were highlighted; and politicians

from Presidents on down were quick to accuse the protesters of the worst intentions, often equating the wider protest movement with the most disruptive actions of a few. Indeed, if the only way to express “radical” was to be militant, media coverage began to invite “expressive politics” —as it continues to do— a politics that can only attract or repel, but can’t really dialogue with those of different perspectives.

Millions of Americans did find those images threatening and/or distasteful, especially when they were told by politicians what “those people” meant. It’s hardly surprising to find the gulf between Americans as wide as it was in the aftermath of Kent State.

But there’s more to this story. By demanding the inclusion of vast numbers of previously marginalized Americans —particularly racial minorities, women, and young people— in the American political economy, the 60s era threatened the political and economic status quo. And political and economic elites responded in kind, especially as economic profitability declined in the 1970s. Vast amounts of corporate and foundation monies launched an information counteroffensive that, along with a right wing media onslaught, is still with us today. Capitalism was revived in a new neoliberal form, serving the interests of the 1%. Ronald Reagan became the perfect spokesperson of the new regime because he voiced conservative values and denounced the 60s while simultaneously turning American politics over to the market place and hence the wealthy.

The thread that runs through the political success of neoliberalism is just that: enact policies that favor the wealthy, but use language that feeds on the very kind of resentments that were fed in the 60s era. Neoliberal policies continue to marginalize the very people who felt left out or alienated by the 60s era —as well as their offspring— but it at least makes them feel they are being heard, that the oligarchs are on their side. Enter Donald Trump, and where we are today.

It remains to be seen if people can come together in the wake of the coronavirus to forge a new way forward. But the need to do so is imperative.

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“U.S. Crimes Don’t Matter”

FARAMARZ FARBOD

The U.S. has a bloody history of trampling on the sovereignty of other nations and committing atrocious acts, including torture, against the peoples of these countries. The U.S. also uses all means it deems necessary to stop others from effectively challenging the impunity it enjoys in the international arena for its nefarious behavior. None of this would be possible without a subservient intelligentsia at home that sets the boundaries of acceptable thought and critique. In this essay I aim to support the above propositions through a brief examination of (1) the use of torture as an instrument of U.S. foreign policy, with a special focus on the first decade of the present century, (2) the U.S. relation with the International Criminal Court (ICC) and President Trump’s recent Executive Order (EO) against that court, and (3) the mainstream liberal critiques of Trump’s ICC EO.

Torture Abroad

Since 1950 the U.S. has developed a covert capacity to torture. Most North Americans are unaware of this fact and that the U.S. has used this capacity where and when it has deemed it necessary globally. When at times the use of torture is exposed or revealed, the mainstream pundits and politicians treat it as an isolated event and as the work of a few rogue elements. They invariably ignore the long history of the CIA working to develop torture techniques and using them from Asia to Latin America: like the CIA’s Phoenix program of torture and assassination that killed up to 50,000 Vietnamese from 1968 to 1972, or the CIA’s help in establishing repressive police and state security forces in numerous countries like Iran, Brazil, Uruguay, Honduras, or the CIA’s drug experiments that were exposed in the U.S. Senate Church Committee in 1975, to name just a few examples. And when at times



Figure 1 Photo: U.S. torture image by Witness Against Torture

the U.S. must refrain from direct use of torture, it can resort to ‘rendition programs’ or the sending of targeted individuals to allied countries that practice direct torture.

The most recent exposure of the use of direct torture by the CIA dates back to 2004 when pictures of Iraqi detainees being tortured in the Abu Ghraib prison surfaced. The U.S. had invaded and occupied Afghanistan in 2001 and Iraq in 2003. The CIA tortured detainees according to a 2014 report by the U.S. Senate Select Committee on Intelligence. What had begun as the use of torture on captured al-Qaeda detainees in Afghanistan soon spread to thousands of Iraqis once resistance to U.S. occupation began in mid-2003. It was then revealed that the U.S. had indeed built a global gulag of torture centers, referred to as ‘black sites,’ in its so-called ‘war on terror.’

The 2014 Senate report [details](#) a variety of torture practices, including “slaps and ‘wallings’ (slamming detainees against a wall)...used in combination, frequently concurrent with sleep deprivation and nudity,” “waterboarding... inducing convulsions and vomiting,” “keeping detainees awake for up to 180 hours, usually standing or in stress positions, at times with their hands shackled above their heads,” “‘rectal rehydration’ or rectal feeding without documented medical necessity,” “ice water ‘baths,’” “threats to harm the children of a detainee, threats to sexually abuse the mother of a detainee, and a threat to ‘cut’ [a detainee’s] mother’s throat,” detainees “kept in complete darkness and constantly shackled in isolated cells with loud noise or music and only a bucket to use for human waste,” “lack of heat” in cold cells, and detainees subjected to “a ‘rough takedown,’ in which approximately five CIA officers would scream at a detainee, drag him outside of his cell, cut his clothes off, and secure him with Mylar tape. The detainees would then be hooded and dragged up and down a long corridor while being slapped and punched.”¹

Clearly, where there is such brutality, rule of law, justice, human rights and dignity vanish.

Impunity for the Strong, Accountability for the Weak

On 11 June 2020 Trump administration, undeterred by a global pandemic and an unprecedented economic shutdown, found the time to sign an EO declaring a ‘national emergency’ and imposing sanctions on the Hague-based ICC, punishing it for its insubordination to the wishes of the U.S. officials. The ICC is the only permanent court with a mandate to hold those responsible for crimes within its jurisdiction accountable to rule of law and justice; these crimes are the crime of genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes, and the crime of aggression. The Trump’s EO revokes the visas of ICC officials, imposes travel restrictions, and freezes the assets and properties of the ICC judges, officials, investigators, lawyers, even witnesses and scholars whose work the court may cite or rely upon, as well as of any other persons, organizations, or even states that may aid the court in its work.

In signing the EO, the U.S. was responding to the ICC decision on 5 March 2020 to authorize its Chief Prosecutor, Fatou Bensouda, to commence an investigation into potential crimes by U.S. Armed Forces and the CIA personnel in Afghanistan, as well as to the Prosecutor’s push to commence a preliminary investigation into potential Israeli crimes in the Palestinian occupied territories. These ICC decisions

represent a potentially important break from the past investigations by the court. The African states have long criticized the ICC for only going after African officials and ignoring the U.S. and European officials and personnel. They African Union even contemplated exiting the Rome Statute. Some critics argue that the ICC has served the interests of the former colonial states and not served its purpose as mandated by the Rome Statute. They urge the ICC to decolonize and stop looking the other way regarding alleged U.S. and European crimes. The ICC decisions on the Afghanistan and Palestine situations could be the break that it needs to gain the respect of many in the Global South.



Figure 2: ICC Prosecutor, Fatou Bensouda

The ICC can commence investigations when cases are referred to it either by the UN Security Council or the states that are party to the court and its founding document (Rome Statute), or if the Prosecutor’s office decides to do so on its own initiative. And therein the latter, lies the trouble from the U.S. perspective. The U.S. controls the UN Security Council via its veto power and has entered into dozens of bilateral agreements with states that are party to the ICC in order to ensure that they would not surrender U.S. nationals to the court for alleged crimes. What the U.S. cannot control is the office of the Chief Prosecutor if that office chooses to pursue investigations into alleged US crimes.

Washington’s main concerns with the ICC (dating back to the early 1990s when the idea of an international criminal court was discussed) have been (1) the Prosecutor’s independent authority to commence investigations in the absence of referrals from either the UN Security Council or states that are party to the court, (2) the court’s jurisdiction over ‘crime of aggression,’ and (3) the court’s claim of jurisdiction over nationals of countries not party to the court. The U.S. insists that ICC’s jurisdiction over crime of aggression be linked first to the Security Council decision determining that a state has committed such an act. The U.S. also worries that the court could initiate investigations against its personnel, even though the U.S. is not

a party to the court, since the court will have jurisdiction over nationals of non-state parties who have allegedly committed crimes in the territories of states who are party to the statute.

The heart of the issue for Washington is how to maintain its impunity in the international arena, a concern that the state and its apologists regularly cloak by stating that they care about protecting “the sovereignty of individual nations.” (‘Sovereignty’ like ‘national security,’ ‘national interest’ and the like have double meanings, a dictionary meaning and another technical one used politically to cloak intent.) To secure that end the U.S. has shown that it will go to any length necessary. For example, a few months after the U.S. invaded Iraq in 2003, Congress passed the American Service-Members’ Protection [Act](#), which required the Bush administration to cut off financial aid to any state party to the ICC that would surrender U.S. nationals to the court and even authorized the U.S. president to rescue any of its or its allies’ personnel held by the ICC² – thereby leading some to refer to the law as “the Hague Invasion Act.”

Years ago, the US dissident Noam Chomsky said that “If the Nuremberg laws were applied, then every post-war American president would have been hanged.” Many may have felt that this is an outrageous commentary worthy of censure in polite company, but it would be folly to think that state officials in high places don’t worry about such prospects. Avoiding prosecution and protecting themselves, including the President, is a top concern of officials wherever it becomes a possibility. Here is how the same [2003 law expressed this fear](#): “In addition to exposing members of the Armed Forces of the United States to the risk of international criminal prosecution, the Rome Statute creates a risk that the President and other senior elected and appointed officials of the United States Government may be prosecuted by the International Criminal Court. Particularly if the Preparatory Commission agrees on a definition of the Crime of Aggression over United States objections, senior United States officials may be at risk of criminal prosecution for national security decisions involving such matters as responding to acts of terrorism, preventing the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction, and deterring aggression. No less than members of the Armed Forces of the United States, senior officials of the United States Government should be free from the risk of prosecution by the International Criminal Court, especially with respect to official actions taken by them to protect the national interests of the United States.”³

It is not just the top U.S. officials who have expressed concern with protecting top officials from criminal investigations and prosecutions. “Israel is preparing a secret list of hundreds of its officials who are liable to be tried in The Hague on war crimes charges. The government is warning them not to travel in case they are arrested.” [Reportedly](#), the list has the names of “between 200 and 300 military and intelligence officials who could be arrested and put on trial for war crimes committed against civilians in the occupied Palestinian territories of the West Bank and the Gaza Strip.”⁴

Hence the Trump administration’s use of sanctions against the ICC for its insubordination to Washington regarding the Afghanistan and Palestine situations.

Mainstream Critics are Apologists for U.S. Aggression

One should not look for liberal or mainstream critics of President Trump’s 11 June EO to take principled stances against U.S. aggression abroad. That much should be clear. However, given the intra-elite strife today regarding the Trump presidency, one is never sure whether an elementary observation that acknowledges the existence of a broad consensus on core U.S. interests abroad needs no repeating.

On the one hand, there are rightwing voices that praise Trump for signing the EO. They consider the ICC to be a supranational court without jurisdiction over the U.S. constitution. They see Trump’s action as “push back against the ICC’s infringement of U.S. sovereignty,” see the ICC engaging in politicized cases against the U.S. and Israel, and Trump as protecting U.S. personnel. “America must not be held accountable to a foreign court,” [said James Carafano](#), vice president of the Davis Institute for National Security and Foreign Policy and E. W. Richardson fellow, “that wants to paint our brave men and women in uniform as monsters.”⁵

Then there are the mainstream critics. Here is one William Burke-White, a University of Pennsylvania law professor and visiting fellow at the Brookings Institution, who served in the Obama administration on the Secretary of State Hillary Clinton’s Policy Planning Staff from 2009-2011. He wrote a [critical piece](#) for Brookings Institution about Trump’s signing of the EO. He criticizes it on several grounds including its ineffectiveness against the court personnel who may be motivated less by finances and more by conscience and who are likely to have little assets to begin with. But his final and most important criticism is rather revealing of the liberal position. “Finally,” he writes, “the use of U.S. sanctions against ICC personnel is a dangerous step toward undermining one of the most powerful and important tools of U.S. foreign policy — international sanctions.” He goes on: “In a world where the use of force is difficult and often ineffective, carefully crafted and strategically applied sanctions are a key tool of U.S. power. For sanctions to work, however, they must be used judiciously and viewed as broadly legitimate. Overuse of sanctions creates incentives for actors to find work-arounds to avoid the pain. Sanctions that are seen as illegitimate fail to garner international cooperation for enforcement and compliance. Applying tough sanctions against the personnel of an international organization undermines their efficacy and legitimacy for times when they could actually advance U.S. national security.”⁶

Here William Burke-White is most concerned that Trump’s ill-advised use of sanctions against the ICC threatens above all to undermine the legitimacy and efficacy of sanctions as a key U.S. foreign policy tool. Note that sanctions are a form of economic warfare with devastating consequences for the people’s livelihood and wellbeing and that the U.S. is currently imposing a form of sanctions on about a third of humanity to punish uncooperative and revisionist states who the U.S. views as challenging its dominance.

Another liberal critic, Rob Berschinski, a Senior Vice President for Policy at Human Rights



Figure 3: official logo of the International Criminal Court

First, and a former Deputy Assistant Secretary of State for Democracy, Human Rights and Labor in the Obama administration, [writes that](#) “the ICC EO threatens to undercut the legitimacy of other important U.S. targeted sanctions programs.” He continues: “Sanctions are among the most important, and most coercive, tools in U.S. foreign policy short of war. The dollar’s position as the world’s reserve currency gives our economic sanctions unprecedented power. And in keeping with a foreign policy that prioritizes unilateralism and frequently shuns expertise, the Trump administration has responded to the United States’ unique position by treating sanctions as a tool of first resort.”⁷

It’s noteworthy that Berschinski is also interested in not giving any ammunition to those we may think of as more principled critics of US policies abroad. “No matter what one thinks of the legitimacy of the ICC’s investigations,” he notes, “threatening the use of the most severe tool in the U.S. diplomatic arsenal against ICC officials plays to the advantage of every critic of unilateral U.S. action.” And who wants that!

“The upshot of this ill-advised decision,” he continues, “will be a delegitimization of U.S. sanctions programs in general.” He worries that “the tool’s overuse will incentivize the EU, China, and other actors to consider ways to evade U.S. sanctions or promote the use of alternative currencies.” He wonders how Trump’s escalation and unilateralism “jeopardizes the kind of international cooperation the United States relies upon to amplify the effect of our sanctions” elsewhere. We get a clear idea of what ‘multilateralism’ means to liberal critics of Trump’s unilateral approach. It does refer to several parties or states working together but it is supposed to function to “amplify” U.S. objectives. Hence, we have another word with both a dictionary and a technical meaning meant to cloak real intentions and interests.

In the end, both Trump’s Executive Order against the ICC and the liberal critics of Trump who embrace US imperialism remind us that we have a long struggle ahead against imperialism and its apologists if we are to reach the ICC’s goal of ending impunity for crime of genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes, and crime of aggression.

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Popular Sovereignty

STEPHEN ERIC BRONNER

“**M**ake America Great Again!” is a slogan based on nostalgia for an “imaginary community;” women were happy in the kitchen, gays were happy in the closet, and people of color were happy doing menial tasks and keeping to themselves. “Everybody” knew that this was how it was supposed to be. Certainty of this sort is gone. Apparently, these subaltern groups were not quite as happy as their white male counterparts thought they were. They protested, organized, and left-wing populists recognized their plight. Especially where the labor movement has been weak and politically unorganized, such as in the United States, left-wing populism has equated the “people” with the “poor,” the disenfranchised, the outcasts, those stripped of identity, and its version of the “average guy.” Left-wing populism calls for inclusion of the excluded, especially immigrants, and basic economic equality. No less than right-wing populists, however, their left-wing rivals are wary of “politicians,” bureaucrats, experts, intellectuals, and republican regimes run by the political establishment. Sensitive to issues of identity, however, their constituency remains a mechanical combination of interests—those of race plus gender plus an empirical view of class—without a serious vision of the organic community.

Where right-wing populists celebrate an anachronistic form of small-town laissez-faire capitalism, without recognizing the system’s centralizing tendencies, left-wing populism is predicated on what Georg Lukács termed “romantic anti-capitalism.” Less a theory than an outlook, it is critical of the capitalist system while remaining blind to the accumulation process and how it operates. Contemptuous of elites, preoccupied with economic equality, left-wing populists have difficulty in dealing with structural conflicts among the exploited. And that is unfortunate since, especially in periods of crisis, deep interest-laden conflicts often become evident: so, for example, a “scissors problem” can arise in which agricultural workers seek high prices for their products and low prices for industrial goods, while urban industrial workers seek the opposite. It is not a matter of which class or group is “poorer.” The issue instead is how to specify their common interest and use it to resolve the conflict—and it is fair to say that populism has few answers. According to Carl Schmitt, indeed, charismatic authority, plebiscites, and the curtailing of checks and balances are necessary to achieve any form of political unity or represent the “nation.”

Sovereign dictatorships target the people by coordinating conflicting interests and highlighting their inner unity. Mechanical compromises play no role in mobilizing the masses and compromise is what the sovereign says it is. This standpoint can be celebrated by the left as well as the right. In general, populism is agnostic when it comes to the sovereign. Unlike socialism, it is not tied to liberal-republican norms or cosmopolitan values. Where labor’s interests were expressed by a socialist party, populism was mostly identified with the political right. That remains the case. European populism employs “new right” slogans that are not very different from those used

by America's white nationalists and fascists. Their idea of community still revolves around the (patriarchal) family, (hegemonic) religion, and (existential) feelings of national belonging. Fear of progress—or, better, decadence—produces the appeal of the anachronistic. The “people's state” (*Volksstaat*), after all, is for those who “belong” as against outsiders, foreigners, and deviants who don't. “Fortress Europe” thus confronts the “alien” or immigrant, with the slogan “Patriotism! Community! Identity!” There is perhaps more confusion over the market and somewhat less contempt for liberal individualism than in times past. Nevertheless, what ultimately differentiates left and right is the concern with an inclusionary as against an exclusionary understanding of sovereignty.

Yet, populism also has an adaptive quality; it vacillates between left and right, and the two opposing interpretations often bleed into one another. From either end of the spectrum, however, populism misses the point, namely, the primary importance of institutional accountability and respect for the rights of minorities. Without the commitment to both, democracy vanishes. Authoritarianism can be imposed either from the top down or the bottom up. It can be launched by the sovereign's suppression of civil liberties or small-town prejudices that ultimately influence powerful politicians; it can arise through terror unleashed by the sovereign or local terror (a lynching or a pogrom) unleashed by the community. It can occur through hierarchical rule that is arbitrary and insular horizontal decision-making that is chaotic and lacks rules of procedure. Sovereigns can employ a propaganda apparatus but citizens can let prejudices go unchecked at the town meeting or the workers' council.

There is room for nuance: right-wing populism exhibits an authoritarian, military and “integral” character lacking on the left. But left-wing populists have also excused (especially non-Western) authoritarian and even religious demagogues so long as they seem engaged in egalitarian economic and social justice projects. Each time there is disappointment: either the leader stays in power too long, or the regimes become corrupt, or temporary terror turns into long-term repression. More is involved than discrete errors of judgment. Left populists like anarchists tend to idealize their version of “the people” without referring to the institutions that represent it. That has also been the case on the right whose members view the enemy as privileging the state over the community, reason over experience, and the universal over identity. If not the republic then its liberal features can thus appear illegitimate to communities within it; that is surely the case with the Buddhist majority in Myanmar and Hindu extremists in India who see no place for the Rohingya or Muslims, respectively, and who have used lynching, hate crimes, Internet hate sites, and other more odious methods to make their point.

Popular sovereignty ignores how “the people” can take on different meanings: it can speak to citizens of a state, members of a nation, or members of a community, race, ethnicity, etc. Impartial rules for resolving grievances among legal citizens are either taken for granted, or deemed, irrelevant (given how politics really works). That they alone serve as bulwarks against authoritarianism is not taken seriously. Equality and liberty require institutions to protect and render them operative. The idea that the “people” somehow retain an inner empathy and feeling for one another, or somehow inherently value the rights of others, is less than naïve; it is dangerous.

Popular sovereignty projects not only a culturally organic community, but harmony between administrative, judicial, political, and economic decision-making. Popular sovereignty wishes to cut through the intermediate associations separating subject and sovereign. This is the case on the left as well as the right so that the community can become identical either with the workers' council or a totalitarian order. Each can employ nostalgic images of a golden age that contests the commodity form, capitalist production, and the existential problems associated with modernity. Left-wing populism has its roots in the Greek polis, the medieval free city, the Levelers, the Anti-Federalists, the American town hall meeting, the Paris Commune of 1789–92, and then 1871, the Russian mass strike of 1905, the workers' councils of 1918–23, and the anarchists during the Spanish Civil War. Its most radical libertarian impulse actually becomes clear in Marx's vision of the classless society in which “the free development of each is the condition for the free development of all.”

Calls for popular sovereignty have accompanied all revolutions. Yet, the phenomenon remains radically undertheorized. Direct democracy's history is not taught, its assumptions are not confronted, its appeal is not critically investigated, and its inherent weaknesses are not engaged. Especially left-wing radical intellectuals living in liberal societies valorize the virtues of everyday people and participatory commitments. They often simply assume the existence of accountable institutions, rules of conflict resolution, specialized expertise, and “book knowledge.” That is also true of checks and balances, separation of powers, and political parties.

Romantic ideas about “inclusion,” what Enrique Dussel termed “the social bloc,” only make sense when conflicting material interests among competing groups are specified. The movement-party, which some believe directly represents the “people,” has always been a staple of fascism. It is the same with the condemnation of intellectuals, elites, and scientists. Coordinating interests and enforcing organizational discipline are issues usually side-stepped on the left: they are reserved principally for sects, presumably because of their unpleasant associations with the past. More sophisticated views suggest that resolving tensions between popular protest and political parties calls for the introduction of a “radical democratic referent.” But this remains metaphysical without practical criteria for deciding on coalitions and compromises, how to deal with contradictory ideological views, competing material interests, and, most importantly, how to define “the people” and its enemies—because, after all, there are always enemies.

In short, which “people” is popular sovereignty intending to represent? Identity, race, and ethnicity can all prove appealing in defining the community and defending it against the Other. Such ideological motivations, however, only create bridges to nowhere. “The people” as a category only makes sense when applied to citizens in a community privileging the liberal rule of law. Inspired by a cosmopolitan sensibility, only with the liberal rule of law in place is it possible to integrate and appreciate traditions and sub-traditions that contribute to other traditions and sub-traditions. The cosmopolitan sensibility can bridge divisions based on identity, race, and ethnicity, but it requires a human rights pedagogy to make clear that “the task of political theory is the determination of the degree to which a power group transcends its particular interests and advocates (in Hegelian terms) universal interests.”

Questions about how to handle such needs are avoided by left-wing and right-wing populists alike. For example, Chantal Mouffe emphasizes the need to organize a “chain of equivalences” within the exploited and disenfranchised in which no single interest or identity is primary. Such a project rests on fostering unity through reliance on “intersectionality,” which ultimately unifies different identities through a certain essence, while keeping diversity or “difference” in place. But these are just words: what results is nothing other than the usual mechanistic idea of a coalition based on class, plus race, plus gender, plus anything else. Organizing principles are non-existent and the result is the usual unity of a contingent social bloc on contingent single issues that then falls apart and then requires contingent recreation when new issues arise—or, better, the constant need to reinvent the wheel.

Left to themselves, in practice if not in theory, interest groups tend to preach solidarity as they ready themselves to sell out their partners. To talk about a social bloc or a chain of equivalence says nothing about the criteria required for setting priorities and judging policies. Solidarity turns into just another slogan unless parts of the “people” are willing to sacrifice for other parts. Dealing with that necessity, ideologically and organizationally, is among the principal political tasks of our time. Conflicts among “the people” are impossible to avoid or dream away: institutions supported by the “people” are necessary to check the ambitions of other people. Without reference to such institutions and political traditions, popular sovereignty is devoid of meaning. The temptation grows to define it in terms of common “experience,” shared cultural values, habits, myths, and emotional ideals of solidarity.

Working behind the scenes, however, an elite minority is plotting against the community and the nation. That an elective affinity should exist between populism and conspiracy theory is not accidental. Just as the “people” can become anything the populist wishes it to be so can the conspiratorial agent: it can be Jews, Freemasons, communists, corporations, or the Queen of England. All have been targets of xenophobic bigotry and, interestingly enough, the stereotypes are usually interchangeable: each has been portrayed as dirty, lazy, culturally retrograde, and “alien.” Conspiracy thinking ultimately relies on rumor, selective facts, and confirmation bias. So, for example, the United States is supposedly under siege on both borders as Arabs enter from the Northeast while, at the same time, Latinos sneak in from the Southwest. Numbers are irrelevant. As conspiracy thinking takes the form of a fetish, and is used to explain even the most incidental events, it provides an illusory sense of understanding and control. Sovereignty neuroses are, meanwhile, fueled by pre-reflective justifications and assumptions that legitimate prejudice and further stoke the fires of conspiracy thinking.

Populists lack analytic categories and criteria for either dealing with political agency or rendering political judgments. Class thus takes on immediate empirical characteristics: the worker becomes the industrial proletarian of times past—usually white, sometimes ethnic, and mostly reactionary. There is talk of rich and poor—“haves and have nots”—that ignores the structural attributes of the working class, such as sale of labor power and class consciousness, as well as the accumulation process and the contradictions it generates. As the need for specialized labor grows, moreover, populists conflate the economic and political hegemony of a capitalist class

with technocratic experts, programmers, and networks in which conflicting agendas apparently just magically appear. Nor do platitudes about family values explain how a broader culture of sleaze has arisen. None of this helps make sense of the world and the heightened frustration only strengthens resentment against “the system” elites as well as the appeal of conspiracy fetishism. Pathological preoccupations with the “deep state,” secretly undermining the will of elected officials and the public interest, is not so different from paranoid beliefs in the “hidden hand” of the Jews manipulating society that appears in the notorious Protocols of the Elders of Zion.

Trust in the community is misplaced. Its outlook is exclusionary regardless of whether it is composed of Christian evangelicals, orthodox Jews, Muslim extremists, or black nationalists. The strength of that insular outlook, however, depends greatly upon the force of symbolism and the power of tradition. If only for this reason, populists are sensitive to criticism regarding their views on history and community. It only follows that they should also prove suspicious of the commodity form, urban existence, and modernizing trends associated with individualism, diversity, secularism, and rationalization of production. Indeed, therein lies Ferdinand Tönnies’ famous distinction between the traditional community (*Gemeinschaft*) of the small town and the dynamic-modern business-oriented society (*Gesellschaft*).

Modern and premodern trends are always in conflict. In fact, the battle between them is the stuff of ideological interests. The dominance of one over the other, moreover, is a contingent matter that is less economic in character than political. Popular sovereignty is a choice with regard to its character and purpose. It can serve as the enemy or ally of traditionalism and small-town life or radical social change and a new and better world. In this regard, there must be a reason why the dissident always looks for support to advocates of modernity. Tradition harbors prejudices and there is simply no reason why minorities should trust the goodwill of those who benefited most from the communities of times past. Women, gays, people of color, dissidents, and workers have all tended to rely less on local governments and community passions than on federal institutions and universal ideals to achieve their ends. The “people’s community” is not the source of humane skepticism, tolerance, cosmopolitanism, or the liberal rule of law. Indeed, for that it is necessary to look elsewhere.

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Finding Privilege in Quarantine

ELAHEH FARMAND

In quarantine, my mother and grandmother recall their time in prison in Iran. They see some similarities: an uncertain future, a sense of fear, a sense that death is closer to home. In lockdown, both women feel restless. My grandmother sits by the telephone in her apartment in Tehran, alone with her god. My mother in the apartment she shares with my father and my older brother in the States, missing visits with her 8 year-old granddaughter. The women have been through this before.

They laugh recalling the memories. It's a bitter laugh of course. But they've both chosen to live and laugh their way through their lives after prison. One does not know how it's possible to endure such hardships unless one lives through similar pains.

But here is a snippet of that pain: You join a revolution, imagining that you will do good for your country. You believe in it so strongly that you give up motherhood even for the sake of saving the children of the entire country. You imagine that this fight for your country's liberation from dictatorship is worth the risk, worth leaving your marriage, worth leaving your children. But the result is unexpected, and the reality of a new regime is even worse than the former. You are arrested and imprisoned for your activism without a fair and just trial. You miss years of motherhood, while facing an uncertain sentence. Death awaits, and everyday you wonder if it's come for you. You watch young lives being taken away, countless executions, countless unjust and unnecessary deaths. You learn of both of your brothers' executions. Your aging father dies, his memory deteriorated from Alzheimer's, and he does not recognize you on his death bed. Your mother is arrested too, and you fear that she will not survive. When you are released from prison at last, your children have grown and you feel as though you've stepped into someone else's life, intruded upon the new lives of your children as they matured faster than most in order to cope with your absence.

Imagining quarantine for five years in a 6 x 6 foot cell, six months of which you spend blindfolded, might be hard. But it gives one perspective, a perspective in which we may recognize and see our privileges. Every minuscule task you can do freely, do not take it for granted. If you can safely walk around your neighborhood, if you can make a cup of coffee and look outside your window, if you can walk freely even within the limits of your room, of your home, do not take them for granted. If you can stay home knowing you are protecting yourself and your neighbors, don't take this for granted. If you have a safe home at all to begin with, don't take that for granted.

Or imagine life in Gaza for instance, where the people are forever imprisoned, where the Israeli government controls everything: how much food the people get, what medicine (if any) they have access to. This genocide is slow and painful, and the above doesn't even begin to summarize it. But learning of such stories, reading about them, educating ourselves is a first step to having perspective, to appreciating our privileges a little more, and perhaps (and hopefully), lead to our awakening as a society.

There are countless stories of bravery to be told. Stories of immigrants who risk everything to leave a suppressed government, to make a better life for their children, parents who will do anything to protect them, who don't have the luxury of privilege, who are constantly in fear, fear of deportation perhaps, fear of uncertainty in a new country, fear of not making ends meet.

I remind myself daily of such stories, and of my own privileges as a documented immigrant, as a citizen. I wish I had fully grasped the magnitude of my privileges in my childhood years, in my teens, even early 20s. My mother once said that I should go back and live in Iran for two years to fully understand how good I have it in America, to grow up and be more mature. It was tough love sure, and I was hurt, with an immense sense of guilt and shame. But I now understand what she meant then. I understand it so well.

I hope we wake up to the reality of the mess we've created, the lack of appreciation for our mother earth, the pollutions we've created, the waste we've produced. I hope we recognize that what we deemed "normal" is not good enough, that the norm we had before the pandemic was toxic, unjust, irrational and that it's our lack of awakening that has led us here. I hope we awaken to the entrapment of capitalism as we struggle with magnitudes of debt to own a house, to have higher education, to have health care. We are entrapped by a capitalist economy where we work more than before for less pay as global wages continue to decrease. We must wake up to class consciousness, organize, and demand that business as usual is not OK, and that is in fact the problem. We must disrupt it; we must dismantle it.

My inherited suffering from my mother's family is hardly comparable to actual suffering, but it allows me this perspective. I hope that we can all continue to share these stories because how can we expect others to awaken if we ourselves are not aware, if we ourselves remain in slumber?

Elaheh Farmand immigrated to the U.S. when she was 11 years-old, leaving her birth country of Iran. In 2016, she founded Immigrants & Exile, a space in which artists can share their feelings of nostalgia, longing, and exile. (www.immigrantsandexile.org)

Homelessness in the Covid-19 Era

RAJAN MENON

The novel SARS-CoV-2 has roared through the American landscape leaving physical, emotional, and economic devastation in its wake. By early July, known infections in this country exceeded three million, while deaths topped 135,000. Home to just over 4% of the global population, the United States accounts for more than a quarter of all fatalities from Covid-19, the disease produced by the coronavirus. Amid a recent surge of infections, especially across the Sun Belt, which Vice President Mike Pence typically denied was even occurring, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) reported that the daily total of infections had reached a record 60,000. Arizona's seven-day average alone approached that of the European Union, which has 60 times as many people.

Making matters much worse, the pandemic erupted during the presidency of Donald J. Trump, whose stratospheric self-absorption, ineptitude, denial of science, and callousness have reached heights even his most ferocious critics couldn't have imagined. His nostrums, including disinfectant, sunlight, and hydroxychloroquine, could be dismissed as comical if they weren't downright dangerous, encouraging possibly fatal experimentation, while breeding false hopes.

Public health safeguards that should have been initiated early on were neglected, above all testing and contact tracing. At the end of April, when President Trump first crowed that "we are the best in the world in testing," the U.S. ranked 22nd in tests per 1,000 people in the 36-member Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development, the club of the globe's wealthy states. Although testing nationwide had increased from 250,000 a day in early May to a current 571,574, that's still less than half the number needed to begin to lock down the virus.

By portraying mask-wearing as effete and elitist, even as those who come near him are tested, disparaging social distancing (recall his reckless rally in Tulsa, Oklahoma, and unmasked Fourth of July celebration at South Dakota's Mount Rushmore), and downplaying the danger of a second wave of infections, President Trump has been the problem, not the solution. It would be hard to imagine a less suitable helmsman to steer this country out of a public health catastrophe. His eternal spin, tweets, and fulminations about "fake news" can't obscure the obvious: his administration's management of the pandemic has been shambolic.

The Variability of Vulnerability

It's common to hear that we're all caught in the Covid-19 crisis, that we're all its victims. Having spread across the country, afflicting people of all backgrounds, it certainly qualifies as a national security crisis, a concept that, militarized for so long now, seems odd when applied to the pandemic. The coronavirus, of course, has neither tanks, nor missiles, nor roadside bombs, and that may help explain the government's abject failure to plan for and contain it.

Still, take a deeper look at Covid-19's destructive path and you'll see that it's been highly selective in the suffering it's caused and the lives it's taken. Adjusted for age, fatalities per 100,000 have been significantly higher for African Americans, Hispanic-Latinx, and Native Americans than for whites across all age groups, as detailed studies demonstrate: for Blacks, 3.6 times higher and for Hispanic-Latinx, 2.5 times. The disparity becomes even greater when the comparison is made by age groups. Ditto hospitalization rates: 40.1/100,000 for whites, 160.7 for Hispanic-Latinx, 178.1 for African Americans, and a whopping 221.2 for Native Americans.

In addition, places with the highest income inequality have had the highest death rates. New York State, which surpasses its counterparts in income disparity, has had a Covid-19 death rate 125 times that of Utah, which has the least inequality. In big metropolitan areas like Los Angeles, New York, and Chicago, where the number of infections has been particularly high, the death rate has unsurprisingly been steepest in low-income communities. People living in such neighborhoods, most of them minorities, are significantly less likely to have health insurance or access to good healthcare services and far more likely to have underlying respiratory ailments including asthma, in part because the air in their communities tends to be more polluted. Poor people also have less chance of surviving Covid-19 because the quality of care in hospitals closely matches the wealth of the neighborhoods they're in.

National economic statistics help highlight Covid-19's uneven effects. Thirty-nine percent of those who have lost their jobs since March made less than \$40,000 a year compared to 19% of those earning \$100,000 or more. In addition, social distancing works for those whose jobs can be done from home, but bus drivers, cabbies, janitors, meatpackers, caregivers, hairdressers, farm workers, home health aides, and the like can't use Zoom to sever themselves from their workplaces. If you don't have to work on-site (and can afford grocery deliveries to your doorstep), you're undoubtedly on the upper rungs of the income ladder. Nearly 62% of those in the 75th income percentile managed to work from home compared to 9.2% of those in the 25th percentile. There are race-based differences as well: 37% of Asian Americans and 30% of whites can work from home versus 19.7% of African Americans and 16.2% of Hispanic-Latinx.

Then there's age. The CDC reports that 80% of those who died from Covid-19 in the United States were 65 or older. The disease has particularly ravaged the elderly in nursing homes (as well as the personnel staffing them), accounting for about 43% of countrywide deaths attributable to the virus.

The upshot: If you're old, poor, and African American or Hispanic-Latinx, your chances of infection are especially high and your odds of survival significantly lower. So, no, we aren't really all in this together, especially since not everybody can easily take elementary safety precautions, certainly not the two million Americans who don't even have running water at home and so can't regularly wash their hands, let alone the Navajo, 30% of whom must drive an hour or more to fetch water. Covid-19, anything but blind to color and class, has visibly hit the most vulnerable segments of American society most fiercely.

Devastating the Homeless

Among those especially hard-pressed to avoid infection and death are people who sleep in shelters, on the street, in deserted buildings, in subway cars, or — and they are perhaps the “lucky” ones — in their own cars. The homeless don’t get all that much Covid-19-related media coverage, in part because they are a sliver of the population (0.2%) and so lack a significant political voice: you won’t find pricey lobbyists working for them in Washington. They can’t even take that most basic precaution advised by medical experts, sheltering in place. To do that, you need dependable shelter, which the homeless, by definition, lack.

If you live in a big city, you can hardly miss the homeless, and you’re undoubtedly familiar with the rituals of passersby. Some simply walk on, perhaps at a slightly quickened pace; others glance at the homeless but ignore, or pretend not to hear, their pleas for help. Some do give them money or food from time to time, knowing that the gesture amounts to slapping a band aid on a serious wound. Even those who see the homeless daily generally know very little about them — who they are, how they ended up on the street, how they manage to survive — and even less about the homeless who, having found a place in a shelter, are out of sight.

While statistics can’t substitute for this lack of knowledge, they can help us grasp the magnitude and nature of homelessness. According to the Department for Housing and Urban Development (HUD), on any given night in January 2019, 560,715 people were homeless. Nearly two-thirds of them lived in shelters. The rest slept wherever they could, often on sidewalks, relying, if in places with cold winters, on steam grates to stay warm. About a quarter of them were deemed “chronically homeless,” which, by the definition HUD adopted in 2015, meant that they had been “living in a place not meant for human habitation, a safe haven, or in an emergency shelter” for 12 months running or for that total over a three-year stretch. Since 2007, when the compilation of data began, homelessness decreased by 12% until 2018-2019 when it rose by 3%, chiefly because of a 16% jump in California. The economic damage done by Covid-19 will, however, ensure yet more future increases.

Four states alone — California, Florida, New York, and Texas — contain nearly half of the homeless. Add Massachusetts, Oregon, Pennsylvania, and Washington, and you’ll hit two-thirds. The vast majority of them live in large urban areas, with five — New York County, Los Angeles County, Seattle/King County, San Jose/Santa Clara County, and San Diego County — accounting for 29% of the homeless nationwide. A clutch of cities (in descending order, Washington, D.C., Boston, and New York) have a homelessness [rate](#) six times the national figure of 17 per 10,000, with San Francisco barely escaping this list of ill-fame.

So, though homelessness exists in every state, as well as in suburbs and rural areas, spatially it’s highly concentrated — and that concentration is racial, not just spatial. Whites comprise 76% of the American population but only 49% of its homeless. For African Americans, the corresponding figures are 13% and 40%, for Hispanic-Latinx Americans 18% and 21%. Native Americans and Native Alaskans, a mere 1.2% of the population, make up nearly 9% of all homeless people. The homelessness rate is similarly skewed: 66.7 per 10,000 for Native Americans and Native

Alaskans, 55 for African Americans, 21.7 for Hispanic/Latinx, 11.5 for whites, and 4 for Asian Americans.

Covid-19 and the Homeless

From the start, the homeless were among the groups most threatened by the coronavirus. Compared to other adults, a far higher proportion of them have respiratory or cardiovascular illnesses, which increase the risk of being infected and reduce chances of survival. Because of the physical wear and tear produced by exposure to the elements, poor nutrition and hygiene, and the stress of living on the streets or in shelters (while fearing being robbed or assaulted), the state of their health resembles that of people who are two decades older. Moreover, an estimated 38% of the homeless are addicted to alcohol and 26% of them to drugs. Substance abuse can, of course, weaken the body’s immune system, putting the homeless at an added disadvantage in warding off the virus.

Some experts claim that infections and deaths among the homeless have belied the direst predictions. Still, by mid-May, the Covid-19 death rate for New York City had reached 187/100,000. In the city’s homeless shelters, however, it was 291/100,000, or 56% higher. A CDC study covering March and April found that in Boston, San Francisco, and Seattle, 25% of the residents and 11% of the staff in homeless shelters tested positive for the virus.

None of this should be surprising. After all, regular handwashing, hard enough for the homeless who don’t live in shelters, became especially so once bathrooms in places like libraries, restaurants, and bus stations were ever less available as the pandemic revved up. Hand sanitizer can, of course, substitute for water, but not if you don’t have enough money to eat regularly, much less buy such products. Psychological disorders create an added barrier to self-protection as about 25% of the homeless — some studies report even higher numbers — suffer from severe mental illness and fewer than half receive any treatment.

Testing and contact tracing have reduced the virus’s spread substantially in a number of countries, but considering how far behind the U.S. has been in both realms, you can bet that the homeless weren’t anywhere near the head of the line for either. In addition, many of the organizations that care for them lack the money, kits, disinfectants, protective gear, and trained personnel (relying as they often do on volunteers) needed for an effective test-and-trace regimen. Fever and coughing were used as markers for testing early in the pandemic, so those in shelters who exhibited neither symptom but were infected transmitted the virus to others unnoticed. A single individual in a San Francisco shelter, for instance, infected 90 fellow residents and 10 employees before he tested positive.

Not surprisingly, the homeless sleeping rough didn’t rush to such shelters in these months, deterred by news that the coronavirus had hit places particularly hard where people were packed together and slept in close quarters, often in bunk beds. The chances of dodging Covid-19 seemed better on the outside.

Moreover, once infections soared, many shelters went into emergency mode. To implement social-distancing mandates and create space to isolate the infected, they froze new admissions or substantially reduced the number of residents they held.

Some even shut down. People seeking beds faced long waiting lists. Meanwhile, cities, already under financial strain from the economic effects of the virus, scrambled to house their homeless in hotels, convention centers, or even in RVs, as the shelters disgorged people, leaving them to fend for themselves. In places like San Francisco's Tenderloin district (already teeming with the homeless), they sleep on the streets or in makeshift tents, which increased nearly threefold citywide. Before long, cities were overwhelmed by costs, logistics, and lack of space. It was one thing for mayors to insist that the unsheltered homeless would be protected, quite another to foot the bill for hotel rooms and basic amenities in places designated for their housing, not to speak of supervisory staff and security.

Could It Get Any Worse?

Covid-19's staggering economic effects will make it ever harder to manage homelessness, especially if its numbers increase due to an upswing in unemployment. Job losses in this country have already been estimated at up to 40 million and, despite the fall in the June unemployment rate, the virus's recent surge across significant parts of the country will make matters worse. Another 10 million workers have seen their work hours or wages cut. Put it all together — the unemployed, those whose earnings have been slashed, and those who have simply stopped looking for work — and the real unemployment rate for May reached something like 21%. Unsurprisingly under such circumstances, in June, 20% of renters and 18% of home owners couldn't make their rent or mortgage payments, while an additional 10% in each category could only pay part of what they owed. Those earning \$24,000 or less had the hardest time with 20% of them unable to pay and 18% paying only in part.

Rent strikes have proliferated and many localities have banned the eviction of those who fall behind on their rent due to pandemic-related circumstances. Yet while such moratoriums can be extended, there's nothing permanent about them. In fact, they have already expired in all or parts of more than a dozen states. Nationally, as many as 23 million renters could face eviction as the fall gets underway and those with low incomes run the greatest risk. Congress included financial assistance (plus a 120-day stay on evictions) for tenants and owners in its March Coronavirus Aid, Relief, and Security bill, but that legislation will expire this summer and Senate Republicans are anything but keen to support a follow-up bill.

The Federal Housing Finance Agency (FHFA) and the Federal Housing Administration (FHA) have banned home foreclosures until August 31st on mortgages backed by them. More than 30 states have also prohibited the filing of home-foreclosure proceedings against, and the eviction of, owners who haven't paid their mortgages for Covid-19-related reasons, though the provisions vary greatly with lots of fine print, and not all will last until the end of the pandemic emergency. Once such moratoriums lapse, renters and owners will be on the hook for missed payments.

Together, prolonged unemployment, reduced earnings for those who retain their jobs, and a decline in savings for workers in the bottom 40% — a trend anyway over the past three decades — are likely to increase homelessness, especially if an eviction spiral begins. Columbia University economist Brendan O'Flaherty, who shared his

data with me, estimates that the economic downturn caused by the virus could drive the number of homeless to 800,000, an increase of 40% to 45% from 2019.

Homelessness could increase for non-economic reasons as well in the Covid-19 era. Take recent moves to reduce the number of people in American prisons, one of the five top hotspots for the spread of the virus. Three-quarters of the inmates at Ohio's Marion Correctional Institution, for instance, tested positive for the disease. At the Cummins prison in Arkansas, 891 inmates and 65 employees tested positive. From mid-May to mid-June alone, infections at U.S. prisons doubled to reach a total of 68,000, while deaths rose by 73% to 616 and had reached 651 by July.

In a rush to diminish population density, prisons and jails started releasing certain categories of inmates, though of this country's 2.1 million prisoners, only about 20,000 have been freed so far, the vast majority from local jails. Keep in mind that people leaving prison have difficulty finding jobs in the best of times, so some of those released to manage the pandemic will undoubtedly find themselves both poverty-stricken and homeless. Even in the pre-pandemic moment, former prisoners were 10 times more likely to become homeless than other Americans and, according to a 2019 study by the Texas Criminal Justice Coalition, striking numbers of them end up in homeless shelters soon after their incarceration ends.

In short, as the coronavirus continues to rage, this country is ill-prepared to handle a surge in homelessness, let alone help those already homeless. The pandemic massively increased the federal deficit. The Congressional Budget Office projects that it could reach \$3.7 trillion in this fiscal year, while other estimates go as high as \$4.3 trillion. Meanwhile, without exception, states face steep drops in revenue.

Sadly, even if the plight of the homeless worsens and their number rises dramatically, it will barely register in the corridors of power. The homeless are a miniscule fraction of the population and have zero political clout. Politicians can safely ignore them, particularly because they know that most voters do and that the media covers homelessness sporadically at best. The homeless, society's all but invisible castaways, can hope for little at a time when they will need more help than ever.

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A Free People Strike to Let Our People Go

BETH TAYLOR, KAREN ALI AND AARON APPEL ON BEHALF OF
FREE PEOPLE STRIKE

Turn on the news. Listen to the radio. Check your social media. Without a doubt, you will find numerous Covid-19 stories – from the infection spikes across the country to the debate about opening schools this fall. But amidst all of this, there is stunning silence on one fact: COVID-19 is worsening in prisons and it is because of state government inaction.

In Pennsylvania, this silence means that the life and death consequences of Governor Wolf's refusal to protect and bring people home from prison goes easily ignored – and that those most affected are forgotten. It means that every day our friends and loved ones inside continue to endure the inhumane trauma of solitary confinement, which is being used as a means of social distancing. And it means that people like Karen Ali, whose husband, Omar, has been incarcerated for over 49 years, could lose him twice – first to our abusive, racist system of incarceration and second to a disease whose spread is being made worse by Governor Wolf's cowardice.

Here is Omar's story, in Karen's own words:

"I am the wife of Omar Askia Ali-Sistrunk. He has been wrongfully incarcerated for 49 years for a crime he had nothing to do with. In 1971 he was picked up while taking his daughters to school, and going to open up his businesses for the day. Omar was a strong and effective advocate for his community and at that time, his biggest challenge as a member of the Nation of Islam, was to run the drugs and the drug dealers out of their community. This targeted him as being bad for business for the dirty, corrupt cops. He was later picked up, arrested, charged, convicted, and sentenced to life without parole.

The corrupt drug dealing cop set...the case...up. The Assistant District Attorney picked the all white jurors. The probable Cause was false. From day one we left no stone unturned to unravel this wrongful conviction. Every discovery, we found, we were able to find documentation.

Omar never saw himself being in prison as the end of his existence. When he came into the violent prison environment at Holmesburg Prison he immediately worked with the commissioner to be a part of the solution not the problem. He developed a nonprofit that lowered the violence and the recidivism. He instituted programs of healthy gardening to life skills. Every prison he was transferred to throughout those 49 years, Omar always became a stabilizer in the environment as he continued to overturn those stones of incarceration.

Omar chronicled his experiences in a book, *The Truth and Nothing But the Truth*, and gives a bird's eye view of the challenges—whether emotional, psychological, spiritual, or physical—that he has had to overcome. At this

time, along comes the coronavirus, which is a death sentence for the vulnerable population. And my husband, along with others, does not deserve to die in prison because they're in lockdown."

The horrible truth is that prisoners are 5.5 times more likely to get Covid-19 and three times more likely to die from it, [according to a study from researchers at Johns Hopkins and UCLA](#) published in JAMA on July 8, 2020. The study also warned that without implementation of more effective infection control, containing the spread of the virus within our prisons is unlikely.

In April, Governor Wolf announced a seemingly bold move and signed a [reprieve order](#) that could have freed 1800 medically vulnerable people from Pennsylvania state prisons and promoted better public health management inside. Compassionate release makes sense for public and community health as the medically vulnerable have particularly low rates of recidivism. However, even if all who are eligible under this order were released, it would hardly make a dent in managing the spread of infection and death in Pennsylvania's crowded, unsanitary prisons.

So in the grand scheme of things, with more than 45,000 people incarcerated in Pennsylvania, Wolf's action was a small one—and he has not even made good on this promise. In more than 3 months, he has released less than 10% of those eligible, increasing the spread and risk of deaths inside and outside the prison walls. In Pennsylvania state facilities ("SCIs"), there is a ballooning number of infections and deaths. At the Huntingdon facility alone, five people have died, and 172 inmates and 54 staff tested positive for COVID-19, while only a single individual was released on reprieve.

Make no mistake—these are fathers, mothers, sisters, brothers, friends, and lovers. These are cherished human beings and the lack of action by Governor Wolf is murderous and unconscionable. To pressure Governor Wolf to safely release people from state prisons and ICE detention during COVID-19, and ensure adequate support to those who remain incarcerated, people and organizations across Pennsylvania have come together to form Free People Strike.

Using a rolling hunger strike, we are committed to giving up as much as we can to bring attention to the plight of those living in prison and to our concern for their lives. We believe that no one should be in cages. Certainly no one should die in them.

[Our demands](#) are adapted from the ACLU-PA, Amistad Law Project, Abolitionist Law Center, ACT-UP Philly, Inside Justice, and Pennsylvania Immigration and Citizenship Coalition and compel Governor Wolf to do the following:

1. Release the 1,800 people eligible under the April 10th reprieve order
2. Expand the reprieve to include people with drug trafficking offenses, technical violations of parole, the medically vulnerable, the elderly, and those who have served 75% of their minimum sentences.
3. Suspend sentences for technical violations of parole.
4. Sign applications for commutations waiting review. (Currently, we are delighted to report that two out of the three applications have been signed.)
5. Ensure those released have reentry resources.

6. Ensure prevention, access to testing, and medical care for those who remain incarcerated.
7. Issue an Emergency Removal Order on the Berks County Residential Center and release all families.

People who are incarcerated have carried out hunger strikes extensively through history as a way of resistance. Our rolling hunger strike is a tribute to the sacrifice and leadership of people striking in prisons historically and currently, including a recent strike at SCI-Albion. We are them and they are us.

Free People Strike aims to be accountable first and foremost to those incarcerated in Pennsylvania prisons and detention centers, the family members of those incarcerated, and the long-standing organizations who have been leading the movement to fight for people incarcerated and detained. Our campaign has been endorsed by more than 25 organizations throughout the state, to whom we are also accountable.

We would like to share, in their own words, why some of our strikers decided to join Free People Strike:

“In both my hunger strike and other actions, I strive to stand in solidarity with the long, ongoing history of both violent and non-violent resistance led by those within prisons who are too often deprived of their audience.

Despite state repression, hunger strikes have been amongst the most common forms of resistance mobilized by incarcerated people globally.

It’s time for those of us outside the prison walls to join them. Amidst COVID-19, rising temperatures, and the countless everyday abuses inflicted upon incarcerated people (including incarceration itself) — now is the time to decarcerate.” —*Sanjeevi Nuhumal, Free People Strike*

“Personally, I hope to use this time as a space of reflection, learning, and action. I also want to bring special attention to the intersections of injustice that make prison populations particularly vulnerable to a pandemic.

The dangers posed to incarcerated persons by COVID-19 do not exist in isolation. The current situation in our nation’s prisons and jails is the expression of a carceral system that institutionalizes the racial and economic status quo. Criminalized groups, including people of color, the mentally ill, queer folk, and those living in poverty (many of these overlapping) face a hostile power structure geared toward policing their lives and livelihoods. Prisons become liminal spaces outside of the scope of societal protection, where human liberties are suspended. This has become increasingly clear during the pandemic.

COVID-19 compounds the violence of an already inhumane criminal justice system. People on the inside are unable to social distance properly, have little (if any) access to quality health care, and are often rendered invisible in the larger societal struggle against the virus.”

—Caitlin Joseph, *Free People Strike*

“As a white person, I think it’s important for me to use my privilege to help dismantle the racist system that has disproportionately put black and brown people behind bars. A system that I’ve benefited from and that most white people, in one way or another, have been complicit in. It’s not enough to raise our voices in solidarity - we must meaningfully and persistently take action.

Every day that Gov. Wolf refuses to use his power of reprieve to protect the people in our prisons and detention centers from COVID is another day of potential wide-spread death sentences. This is unacceptable and taking part in this hunger strike is a powerful way to intensify the voices of those already doing this work and to apply maximum pressure to Wolf.”

—Beth Taylor, *Free People Strike & End Mass Incarceration Lehigh Valley*

No matter why each of us has chosen to join Free People Strike, we all deeply affirm the need to free the vulnerable, to reunify families, and to value the lives of all of us, no matter which side of the prison bars we may reside on. We show unity and demand recognition of the fundamental dignity and interconnectedness that we all share as we move forward and build the world that we all deserve.

How You Can Join Us

1. Join the rolling hunger strike for at least five days. Sign up at [here](#).
2. Join a Solidarity Strike on Wednesdays by signing up [here](#).
3. [Sign this petition](#) and share.
4. Call Wolf daily at 717-787-2500. Ask him what he’s doing about vulnerable people in prisons. Call log [here](#).
5. Think about your strengths and how else you can support this work and reach out to us.
6. Demands: bit.ly/freepeoplestrike
7. Website: linktr.ee/freepeoplestrike
8. Social Media: @freepeoplestrike
9. Email: freepeoplestrike@gmail.com
10. If you feel moved to support Omar Askia Ali-Sistrunk in his struggle for freedom, you can reach out to Karen Ali at karenskrowns@yahoo.com.

Karen Ali is a leading organizer with the Human Rights Coalition and is the wife of Omar Askia Ali-Sistrunk. Although she is in her 70s, she has committed to two hunger strikes.

Aaron Appel, a member of the Human Rights Coalition, joined the Free People Strike as a hunger striker and member of their striker onboarding team.

Beth Taylor is a Lehigh Valley community activist, member of End Mass Incarceration Lehigh Valley (justice.pppj.org), and co-leader of the Lehigh Valley Chapter of March on Harrisburg.

* For links, see online version at www.sustainlv.org/a-free-people-strike-to-let-our-people-go.

How Che Guevara Taught Cuba to Confront COVID-19

DON FITZ

Beginning in December 1951, Ernesto “Che” Guevara took a nine-month break from medical school to travel by motorcycle through Argentina, Chile, Peru, Colombia, and Venezuela. One of his goals was gaining practical experience with leprosy. On the night of his twenty-fourth birthday, Che was at La Colonia de San Pablo in Peru swimming across the river to join the lepers. He walked among six hundred lepers in jungle huts looking after themselves in their own way.

Che would not have been satisfied to just study and sympathize with them – he wanted to be with them and understand their existence. Being in contact with people who were poor and hungry while they were sick transformed Che. He envisioned a new medicine, with doctors who would serve the greatest number people with preventive care and public awareness of hygiene. A few years later, Che joined Fidel Castro’s 26th of July Movement as a doctor and was among the eighty-one men aboard the Granma as it landed in Cuba on December 2, 1956.

Revolutionary Medicine

After the January 1, 1959, victory that overthrew Fulgencio Batista, the new Cuban constitution included Che’s dream of free medical care for all as a human right. An understanding of the failings of disconnected social systems led the revolutionary government to build hospitals and clinics in underserved parts of the island at the same time that it began addressing crises of literacy, racism, poverty, and housing. Cuba overhauled its clinics both in 1964 and again in 1974 to better link communities and patients. By 1984, Cuba had introduced doctor-nurse teams who lived in the neighborhoods where they had offices (*consultorios*).

The United States became ever more bellicose, so in 1960 Cubans organized Committees for Defense of the Revolution to defend the country. The committees prepared to move the elderly, disabled, sick, and mentally ill to higher ground if a



San Pablo leper colony

hurricane approached, thus intertwining domestic health care and foreign affairs, a connection that has been maintained throughout Cuba’s history.

As Cuba’s medical revolution was based on extending medical care beyond the major cities and into the rural communities that needed it the most, it was a logical conclusion to extend that assistance to other nations. The revolutionary government sent doctors to Chile after a 1960 earthquake and a medical brigade in 1963 to Algeria, which was fighting for independence from France. These set the stage for the country’s international medical aid, which grew during the decades and now includes helping treat the COVID-19 pandemic.

In the late 1980s and early ’90s, two disasters threatened the very existence of the country. The first victim of AIDS died in 1986. In December 1991, the Soviet Union collapsed, ending its \$5 billion annual subsidy, disrupting international commerce, and sending the Cuban economy into a free fall that exacerbated the AIDS epidemic. A perfect storm for AIDS infection appeared on the horizon. The HIV infection rate for the Caribbean region was second only to southern Africa, where a third of a million Cubans had recently been during the Angolan wars. The embargo on the island reduced the availability of drugs (including those for HIV/AIDS), made existing pharmaceuticals outrageously expensive, and disrupted the financial infrastructures used for drug purchases. Desperately needing funds, Cuba opened the floodgate of tourism.

The government drastically reduced services in all areas except two: education and health care. Its research institutes developed Cuba’s own diagnostic test for HIV by 1987. Over twelve million tests were completed by 1993. By 1990, when gay people had become the island’s primary HIV victims, homophobia was officially challenged in schools. Condoms were provided for free at doctor’s offices and, despite the expense, so were antiretroviral drugs.

Cuba’s united and well-planned effort to cope with HIV/AIDS paid off. At the same time that Cuba had two hundred AIDS cases, New York City (with about the same population) had forty-three thousand cases. Despite having only a small fraction of the wealth and resources of the United States, Cuba had overcome the devastating effects of the U.S. blockade and had implemented an AIDS program superior to that of the country seeking to destroy it. During this Special Period, Cubans experienced longer lives and lower infant mortality rates in comparison to the United States. Cuba had inspired healers throughout the world to believe that a country with a coherent and caring medical system can thrive, even against tremendous odds.

COVID-19 Hits Cuba

Overcoming the HIV/AIDS and Special Period crises prepared Cuba for COVID-19. Aware of the intensity of the pandemic, Cuba knew that it had two inseparable responsibilities: to take care of its own with a comprehensive program and to share its capabilities internationally.

The government immediately carried out a task that proved very difficult in a market-driven economy — altering the equipment of nationalized factories (which usually made school uniforms) to manufacture masks. These provided an ample sup-

ply for Cuba by the middle of April 2020, while the United States, with its enormous productive capacity, was still suffering a shortage.

Discussions at the highest levels of the Cuban Ministry of Public Health drew up the national policy. There would need to be massive testing to determine who had been infected. Infected persons would need to be quarantined while ensuring that they had food and other necessities. Contact tracing would be used to determine who else might be exposed. Medical staff would need to go door to door to check on the health of every citizen. *Consultorio* staff would give special attention to everyone in the neighborhood who might be high risk.

By March 2, Cuba had instituted the [Novel Coronavirus Plan for Prevention and Control](#). Within four days, it expanded the plan to include taking the temperature of and possibly isolating infected incoming travelers. These occurred before Cuba's first confirmed COVID-19 diagnosis on March 11. Cuba had its [first confirmed COVID-19 fatality](#) by March 22, when there were thirty-five confirmed cases, almost one thousand patients being observed in hospitals, and over thirty thousand people under surveillance at home. The next day it banned the entry of nonresident foreigners, which took a deep bite into the country's tourism revenue.

That was the day that Cuba's Civil Defense went on alert to respond rapidly to COVID-19 and the Havana Defense Council decided that there was a serious problem in the city's Vedado district, famous for being the largest home to nontourist foreign visitors who were more likely to have been exposed to the virus. By April 3, the district was closed. As Merriam Ansara witnessed, "anyone with a need to enter or leave must prove that they have been [tested and are free of COVID-19](#)." The Civil Defense made sure stores were supplied and all vulnerable people received regular medical checks.

Vedado had eight confirmed cases, a lot for a small area. Cuban health officials wanted the virus to remain at the "local spread" stage, when it can be traced while going from one person to another. They sought to prevent it from entering the "community spread" stage, when tracing is not possible because it is moving out of control. As U.S. health professionals begged for personal protective equipment and testing in the United States was so sparse that people had to ask to be tested (rather than health workers testing contacts of infected patients), Cuba had enough rapid test kits to trace contacts of persons who had contracted the virus.

During late March and early April, Cuban hospitals were also changing work patterns to minimize contagion. Havana doctors went into Salvador Allende Hospital for fifteen days, staying overnight within an area designated for medical staff. Then they moved to an area separate from patients where they lived for another fifteen days and were tested before returning home. They stayed at home without leaving for another fifteen days and were tested before resuming practice. This forty-five-day period of isolation prevented medical staff from bringing disease to the community via their daily trips to and from work.

The medical system extends from the *consultorio* to every family in Cuba. Third-, fourth-, and fifth-year medical students are assigned by *consultorio* doctors to go to specific homes each day. Their tasks include obtaining survey data from residents or making extra visits to the elderly, infants, and those with respiratory problems. These visits gather preventive medicine data that is then taken into account by those in the

highest decision-making positions of the country. When students bring their data, doctors use a red pen to mark hot spots where extra care is necessary. Neighborhood doctors meet regularly at clinics to talk about what each doctor is doing, what they are discovering, what new procedures the Cuban Ministry of Public Health is adopting, and how the intense work is affecting medical staff.

In this way, every Cuban citizen and every health care worker, from those at neighborhood doctor offices through those at the most esteemed research institutes, has a part in determining health policy. Cuba currently has eighty-nine thousand doctors, eighty-four thousand nurses, and nine thousand students scheduled to graduate from medical studies in 2020. The Cuban people would not tolerate the head of the country ignoring medical advice, spouting nonsensical statements, and determining policy based on what would be most profitable for corporations.

The Cuban government approved free distribution of the [homeopathic medicine PrevengHo-Vir](#) to residents of Havana and Pinar del Rio province. Susana Hurlich was one of many receiving it. On April 8, Dr. Yaisen, one of three doctors at the *consultorio* two blocks from her home, came to the door with a small bottle of PrevengHo-Vir and explained how to use it. Instructions warn that it reinforces the immune system but is not a substitute for Interferon Alpha 2B, nor is it a vaccine. Hurlich believes that something important "about Cuba's medical system is that rather than being two-tiered, as is often the case in other countries, with 'classical medicine' on the one hand and 'alternative medicine' on the other, Cuba has [ONE health system that includes it all](#). When you study to become a doctor, you also learn about homeopathic medicine in all its forms."

Global Solidarity in the Time of COVID-19

A powerful model: Perhaps the most critical component of Cuba's medical internationalism during the COVID-19 crisis has been using its decades of experience to create an example of how a country can confront the virus with a compassionate and competent plan. Public health officials around the world were inspired by Cuba's actions.

Transfer of knowledge: When viruses that cause Ebola, mainly found in sub-Saharan Africa, increased dramatically in the fall of 2014, much of the world panicked. Soon, over twenty thousand people were infected, more than eight thousand had died, and worries mounted that the death toll could reach into hundreds of thousands. The United States provided military support; other countries promised money. Cuba was the first nation to respond with what was most needed: it sent 103 nurse and 62 doctor volunteers to Sierra Leone. Since many governments did not know how to respond to the disease, Cuba trained volunteers from other nations at Havana's Pedro Kourí Institute of Tropical Medicine. In total, Cuba taught 13,000 Africans, 66,000 Latin Americans, and 620 Caribbeans how to treat Ebola without themselves becoming infected. Sharing understanding on how to organize a health system is the highest level of knowledge transfer.

Venezuela has attempted to replicate fundamental aspects of the Cuban health model on a national level, which has served Venezuela well in combating COVID-19. In 2018, residents of Altos de Lidice organized seven communal councils, including

one for community health. A resident made space in his home available to the Communal Healthcare System initiative so that Dr. Gutierrez could have an office. He coordinates data collections to identify at-risk residents and visits all residents in their homes to explain how to avoid infection by COVID-19. Nurse del Valle Marquez is a Chavista who helped implement the Barrio Adentro when the first Cuban doctors arrived. She remembers that residents had never seen a doctor inside their community, but when the Cubans arrived “we opened our doors to the doctors, they lived with us, they ate with us, and [they worked among us](#).”

Stories like this permeate Venezuela. As a result of building a Cuban-type system, teleSUR reported that by April 11, 2020, the Venezuelan government had conducted 181,335 early Polymerase Chain Reaction tests in time to have the [lowest infection rate in Latin America](#). Venezuela had only 6 infections per million citizens while neighboring Brazil had 104 infections per million.

When Rafael Correa was president of Ecuador, over one thousand Cuban doctors formed the backbone of its health care system. Lenin Moreno was elected in 2017 and Cuban doctors were soon expelled, leaving public medicine in chaos. Moreno followed recommendations of the International Monetary Fund to slash Ecuador’s health budget by 36 percent, leaving it without health care professionals, without personal protective equipment, and, above all, without a coherent health care system. While Venezuela and Cuba had 27 COVID-19 deaths, Ecuador’s largest city, Guayaquil, had an estimated [death toll of 7,600](#).

International medical response: Cuban medicine is perhaps best known for its internationalism. A clear example is the devastating earthquake that rocked Haiti in 2010. Cuba sent medical staff who lived among Haitians and stayed months or years after the earthquake. U.S. doctors, however, did not sleep where Haitian victims huddled, returned to luxury hotels at night, and departed after a few weeks. John Kirk coined the term disaster tourism to describe the way that many rich countries respond to medical crises in poor countries.

The commitment that Cuban medical staff show internationally is a continuation of the effort that the country’s health care system made in spending three decades to find the best way to strengthen bonds between caregiving professionals and those they serve. By 2008, Cuba had sent over 120,000 health care professionals to 154 countries, its doctors had cared for over 70 million people in the world, and almost 2 million people owed their lives to Cuban medical services in their country.

The [Associated Press](#) reported that when COVID-19 spread throughout the world, Cuba had thirty-seven thousand medical workers in sixty-seven countries. It soon deployed additional doctors to Suriname, Jamaica, Dominica, Belize, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, St. Kitts and Nevis, Venezuela, and Nicaragua. On April 16, [Granma reported](#) that “21 brigades of healthcare professionals have been deployed to join national and local efforts in 20 countries. The same day, Cuba sent [two hundred health personnel to Qatar](#).”

As northern Italy became the epicenter of COVID-19 cases, one of its hardest hit cities was Crema in the Lombardy region. The emergency room at its hospital was filled to capacity. On March 26, Cuba sent fifty-two doctors and nurses who set up a field hospital with three intensive care unit beds and thirty-two other beds with

oxygen. A smaller and poorer Caribbean nation was one of the few aiding a major European power. Cuba’s intervention took its toll. By April 17, thirty of its medical professionals who went abroad [tested positive for COVID-19](#).

Bringing the world to Cuba: The flip side of Cuba sending medical staff across the globe is the people it has brought to the island — both students and patients. When Cuban doctors were in the Republic of the Congo in 1966, they saw young people studying independently under streetlights at night and arranged for them to come to Havana. They brought in even more African students during the Angolan wars of 1975–88 and then brought large numbers of Latin American students to study medicine following Hurricanes Mitch and Georges. The number of students coming to Cuba to study expanded even more in 1999 when it opened classes at the Latin American School of Medicine (ELAM). By 2020, ELAM had trained thirty thousand doctors from over one hundred countries.

Cuba also has a history of bringing foreign patients for treatment. After the 1986 nuclear meltdown at Chernobyl, 25,000 patients, mostly children, came to the island for treatment, with some staying for months or years. Cuba opened its doors, hospital beds, and a youth summer camp.

On March 12, nearly fifty crew members and passengers on a British cruise ship either had COVID-19 or were showing symptoms as the ship approached the Bahamas, a British Commonwealth nation. Since the Braemar flew the Bahamian flag as a Commonwealth vessel, there should have been no problem disembarking those aboard for treatment and return to the United Kingdom. But the Bahamian Ministry of Transport declared that the cruise ship would “not be permitted to dock at any port in the Bahamas and [no persons will be permitted to disembark](#) the vessel.” During the next five days, the United States, Barbados (another Commonwealth nation), and several other Caribbean countries turned it away. On March 18, Cuba became the only country to allow the Braemar’s over one thousand crew members and passengers to dock. Treatment at Cuban hospitals was offered to those who felt too sick to fly. Most went by bus to José Martí International Airport for flights back to the United Kingdom. Before leaving, Braemar crew members displayed a banner reading “[I love you Cuba!](#)” Passenger Anthea Guthrie posted on her Facebook page: “They have made us not only feel tolerated, [but actually welcome](#).”

Medicine for all: In 1981, there was a particularly bad outbreak of the mosquito-borne dengue fever, which hits the island every few years. At the time, many first learned of the very high level of Cuba’s research institutes that created Interferon Alpha 2B to successfully treat dengue. As Helen Yaffe points out, “Cuba’s interferon has shown its efficacy and safety in the [therapy of viral diseases](#) including Hepatitis B and C, shingles, HIV-AIDS, and dengue.” It accomplished this by preventing complications that could worsen a patient’s condition and result in death. The efficacy of the drug persisted for decades and, in 2020, it became vitally important as a potential cure for COVID-19. What also survived was Cuba’s eagerness to develop a multiplicity of drugs and share them with other nations.

Cuba has sought to work cooperatively toward drug development with countries such as China, Venezuela, and Brazil. Collaboration with Brazil resulted in meningitis vaccines at a cost of 95¢ rather than \$15 to \$20 per dose. Finally, Cuba teaches

other countries to produce medications themselves so they do not have to rely on purchasing them from rich countries.

In order to effectively cope with disease, drugs are frequently sought for three goals: tests to determine those infected; treatments to help ward off or cure problems; and vaccines to prevent infections. As soon as Polymerase Chain Reaction rapid tests were available, Cuba began using them widely throughout the island. Cuba developed both Interferon Alpha 2B (a recombinant protein) and PrevengHo-Vir (a homeopathic medication). TeleSUR reported that by April 20, over forty-five countries had requested [Cuba's Inteferon](#) in order to control and then get rid of the virus.

Cuba's Center for Genetic Engineering and Biotechnology is seeking to create a vaccine against COVID-19. Its Director of Biomedical Research, Dr. Gerardo Guillén, confirmed that his team is collaborating with Chinese researchers in Yongzhou, Hunan province, to create a vaccine to stimulate the immune system and one that can be taken through the nose, which is the route of COVID-19 transmission. Whatever Cuba develops, it is certain that it will be shared with other countries at low cost, unlike U.S. medications that are patented at taxpayers' expense so that private pharmaceutical giants can price-gouge those who need the medication.

Countries that have not learned how to share: Cuban solidarity missions show a genuine concern that often seems to be lacking in the health care systems of other countries. Medical associations in Venezuela, Brazil, and other countries are often hostile to Cuban doctors. Yet, they cannot find enough of their own doctors to go to dangerous communities or travel to poor and rural areas as Cuban doctors do.

When in Peru in 2010, I visited the Pisco policlínico. Its Cuban director, Leopoldo García Mejías, explained that then-president Alan García did not want additional Cuban doctors and that they had to keep quiet in order to remain in Peru. Cuba is well aware that it has to adjust each medical mission to accommodate the political climate.

There is at least one exception to Cuban doctors remaining in a country according to the whims of the political leadership. Cuba began providing medical attention in Honduras in 1998. During the first eighteen months of Cuba's efforts in Honduras, the country's infant mortality dropped from 80.3 to 30.9 deaths per 1,000 live births. Political moods changed and, in 2005, Honduran Health Minister Merlin Fernández decided to kick Cuban doctors out. However, this led to so much opposition that the government changed course and allowed the Cubans to stay.

A disastrous and noteworthy example of when a country refused an offer of Cuban aid is the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina in 2005. After the hurricane hit, 1,586 Cuban health care professionals were prepared to go to New Orleans. President George W. Bush, however, rejected the offer, acting as if it would be better for U.S. citizens to die rather than to admit the quality of Cuban aid.

Though the U.S. government does not take kindly to students going studying at ELAM, they are still able to apply what they learn when they come home. In 1988, Kathryn Hall-Trujillo of Albuquerque, New Mexico, founded the Birthing Project USA, which trains advocates to work with African-American women and connect with them through the first year of the infant's life. She is grateful for the Birthing Project's partnership with Cuba and the support that many ELAM students have

given. In 2018, she told me: "We are a coming home place for ELAM students—they see working with us as a way to put into practice what they learned at ELAM."

Cuban doctor Julio López Benítez recalled in 2017 that when the country revamped its clinics in 1974, the old clinic model was one of patients going to clinics, but the new model was of clinics going to patients. Similarly, as ELAM graduate Dr. Melissa Barber looked at her South Bronx neighborhood during COVID-19, she realized that while most of the United States told people to go to agencies, what people need is a community approach that recruits organizers to go to the people. Dr. Barber is working in a coalition with South Bronx Unite, the Mott Haven Mamas, and many local tenant associations. As in Cuba, they are trying to identify those in the community who are vulnerable, including "the elderly, people who have infants and small children, homebound people, people that have multiple morbidities and are really [susceptible to a virus like this one](#)."

As they discover who needs help, they seek resources to help them, such as groceries, personal protective equipment, medications, and treatment. In short, the approach of the coalition is going to homes to ensure that people do not fall through the cracks. In contrast, the U.S. national policy is for each state and each municipality to do what it feels like doing, which means that instead of having a few cracks that a few people fall through, there are enormous chasms with large groups careening over the edge. What countries with market economies need are actions like those in the South Bronx and Cuba carried out on a national scale.

This was what Che Guevara envisioned in 1951. Decades before COVID-19 jumped from person to person, Che's imagination went from doctor to doctor. Or perhaps many shared their own visions so widely that, after 1959, Cuba brought revolutionary medicine anywhere it could. Obviously, Che did not design the intricate inner workings of Cuba's current medical system. But he was followed by healers who wove additional designs into a fabric that now unfolds across the continents. At certain times in history, thousands or millions of people see similar images of a different future. If their ideas spread broadly enough during the hour that social structures are disintegrating, then a revolutionary idea can become a material force in building a new world.

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Updates since this article was written for the June 2020 print issue of [Monthly Review](#) include the following: By May 22, seventy-two countries had requested [Interferon Alpha 2B](#). Cuba has sent [healthcare professionals](#) to at least thirty-seven countries to collaborate in combating the pandemic. Over the past six decades [over 400,000 Cuban medical professionals](#) have worked in 164 countries and improved the lives of hundreds of millions of people.

A poem by Raymond Nat Turner

Shooting and looting started:
400 years ago

Shooting, looting, scalping, lynching,

Raping, torturing their way across
the continent — 400 years ago —

Colonial settler thugs launched this
endless crimson tide rolling down on

Today...

Colonial settler thugs launched this
endless crimson tide leaving in-
visible yellow crime
scene tape crisscrossing Tallahassee
to Seattle; San Diego to Bangor...

Shooting Seneca, Seminole, Creek,
Choctaw, Mohawk, Cayuga, Blackfeet,

Shooting Sioux, Shawnee, Chickasaw,
Chippewa before

Looting Lakota land; Looting Ohlone

Land —

Looting Ashanti, Fulani, Huasa, Wolof,
Yoruba, Ibo, Kongo, Mongo, Hutu, Zulu...

Labor.

Colonial settler thugs launched this
endless crimson tide — hot lead storms —

Shooting, looting Mexico for half of New
Mexico; a quarter of Colorado; some of

Wyoming and most of Arizona; Looting
Mexico for Utah, Nevada and California

So, next time Orange Mobutu, Boss Tweet,
is dirty like Duterte — howling for shooting;

Next time demented minions raise rifles to
shoot; Remind them that

Real looters wear Brooks Brothers suits;

Or gold braid and junk medals 'cross their
 chests. Real looters — with Capitalist Hill

Accomplices —

Steal trillions

Not FOX-boxes, silly sneakers, cheap clothes...

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Raymond Nat Turner is Black Agenda Report's poet in residence and is an accomplished performing artist. You can find much more of his work at upsurgejazz.com

Transnational Feminist Activism in Latin America and Beyond

RACHEL O'DONNELL

Transnational feminist movements have made a profound contribution to a realization of global feminist politics and international development more generally. Since these movements are not often recognized or covered in mainstream media, it can be difficult to gather a complete understanding of the ways in which gender equality is gaining ground globally, through the dedicated work of collective organizing among transnational feminists.

I would like to connect what is happening in transnational movements to specific examples of feminist organizing in Latin America and how it moves transnationally—across borders—to other groups of feminist organizers who in turn use this transnational power for more fundamental global and local change. The particular issue of the economy has come up repeatedly, as transnational feminism has worked to educate around capitalism and dismantle its institutions. It is our job as activists to understand and promote the wealth of histories and actions of transnational feminist movements, and reflect critically on their global contributions to knowledge, policy and social change, especially when we think about international development and the Global South. It also serves us to critique these movements and ask searching questions about where we would go next and what kind of world we want. By connecting how feminist movements have taken on ‘transnational’ economic concepts recently, including how these movements have broadened the concept of what we mean by the Third World or Global North, we can track the power of global movements more clearly, even from the history of feminist organizing in Latin America to recent calls for gender equity in Hawai‘i.

When did discussion of global gender politics become commonplace? By the end of the 20th century, a global women’s movement had emerged. Some argue that the ‘transnational’ pieces of this movement began with the idea of gender and women’s rights taking hold in the mainstream, beginning with a mid-20th century women’s movement in the Global North. The UN world conferences on women (1975–1995) and the global conferences of the 1990s allowed feminists from the South and North to meet and debate in person, as well as articulate an expanding global vision of not only women’s rights but of gender equality. This call for ‘diversity,’ or what is now more clearly articulated as the continued inclusion of gender minorities and women from the Global South, emerged as many asked for Global North feminists in particular to stop denigrating ‘Third World women’ within and apart from these movements and institutions. Feminists have even deliberately pointed to resulting assumptions about such “third world women:” “ignorant, poor, uneducated, tradition-bound, domestic, family-oriented, victimized, etc.” (Mohanty 56). When it comes to international development work, development is often synonymous with economic development and capitalist progress—in the substitution of “women’s activity” for “labor,” for

example—relationships between women and the global order seem to exist outside of social formations. This is often purposeful, as global institutions such as the World Bank offer analyses predicated on keeping the global system as it is. Such analyses, instead of attempting to analyze social relations to understand the structures through which the lives of women are constituted, make many assumptions about individuals. What transnational feminist organizing has done is articulate feminist priorities while making certain to not “include” women as an afterthought, but as central to arguments for global restructuring. Global conferences in part enabled transnational feminist movements from the Global South to emerge as a force, both within and outside global governance institutions, in ways that continue to inform the last half century of feminist organizing.

Transnational feminist movements from the South responded to these assumptions about the nature of their lives from the North. As a result, they have become groups of committed individuals who work in feminist organizing, but also developed into organizations, networks, coalitions, campaigns, and advocacy groups that politicize women’s rights and gender equality issues beyond the nation-state. These groups emerged more clearly in the 1990s, when deepening globalization and new communications technologies allowed feminist organizers to connect and interrogate their local and global situations. When we explore the historical, political, economic, and social contexts in which transnational feminist movements have emerged and evolved, we see how several definitions of transnational feminist movements are considered and debated.

Transnational feminist networks have been defined as “mobilizations that advocate for women’s participation and rights while also engaging critically with policy and legal issues and with states, international organizations, and institutions of global governance” (Moghadam 2005). Transnational feminist networks often bring together groups of women from multiple nations around a specific set of grievances and goals, often women’s human rights, health or economic justice. Non-hierarchical structures in these organizations can span local and global spaces, and such networks often engage extensively in cyber activism. Moghadam has categorized four types of contemporary transnational feminist networks: (1) those that target the neoliberal economic policy agenda; (2) those that focus on the danger of fundamentalisms and insist on women’s human rights, especially in the Muslim world; (3) women’s peace groups that target conflict, war, and empire; and (4) networks engaged in feminist humanitarianism and international solidarity (2013). Others have added body politics, citizenship and state-building, political ecology, and digital-age transformation.

One example of this type of organizing happens among feminist networks across Latin America that merge the local and global. Feminists across Latin America have contributed new ways of defining democracy, building their distinct identities, theories, and paradigms from different streams, campaigning against women’s exclusion from and subordination in the public and private spheres; urban women have confronted women’s traditional roles and the public-private divide; and women in political parties and trade unions have questioned “the democratic dynamics inside these traditional spaces of male legitimacy” (Moghadam 2013, 20). Latin American femi-

nists have consistently politicized the private sphere, which included women bringing their “private” grief for their disappeared children into the public sphere and challenging patriarchal and authoritarian regimes; feminists making visible what until then had remained nameless: domestic violence, sexual harassment, rape, and the feminization of poverty. Chilean feminists, in their fight against the Pinochet dictatorship of the 20th century, often extended the concept of democracy—politically and theoretically—with their slogan “democracy in the country and in the home.” In the 1990s, and continuing into the twenty-first century, Latin American feminists challenged the myth of the unitary nation on which the imagery of the state had been built. The Latin American and Caribbean feminist *encuentros* (encounters), first held in Bogotá, Colombia in 1981, have served as critical transnational sites in which local activists have adopted practices distinctive of the region’s feminisms.

“Un violador en tu camino” (A rapist in your path)



Women performing “A Rapist in Your Path” in Alameda Central (Photo: cc-sa 4.0 Carmen Alcázar)

These practices continue. On November 25 of last year (2019), the International Day for the Elimination of Violence Against Women, hundreds of women gathered around the Chilean capital of Santiago to denounce gendered violence. The women danced while declaring “¡Y la culpa no era mía, ni dónde estaba ni cómo vestía!” (“And it was not my fault, or where I was, or how I was dressed!”) The most important part of their chants, however, is that of the shifting of blame away from women who experience sexual violence and onto the state; activists pointed to functionaries such as the police, judges, and the president declaring, “¡El violador eres tú!” (“The rapist is you!”), “¡El estado opresor es un macho violador!” (“The oppressive state is a male rapist!”). The protest, named “Un Violador en tu camino,” went viral, and activists in Puerto Rico and Mexico have since used the same phrasing to bring attention to the ongoing local struggles against femicides and continued colonial exploitation, and even to advocate for education that prioritizes a gendered perspective.

Rather than articulating a private problem of sexist behavior, this form of activism in Chile demonstrates how much what is considered ‘gendered’ is a public problem of larger global and state apparatuses that participate in and facilitate violence against women, and in turn, must be confronted in the open. Activists have made use of a song and its message of larger social formations—not individuals—into wider circulation. “Un violador en tu camino” in Chile and other sites around the globe has been a feminist transnational performance that enhances the global movement and also amplifies local struggles.

Escalating and mobilizing global strikes is a tactic that emerged in Latin America and consistently spread beyond. With the *Paro Internacional de Mujeres*, or International Women’s Strike (IWS), organizers—from Buenos Aires to Bogotá to New York City—have aimed to bring attention to the many forms of unacknowledged and undercompensated labor mostly performed by women, such as childcare, eldercare, and intimate labor. Organizing through popular assemblies, strike activists have declared their movement to embrace a “feminism of the 99%” every year since 2015. On the day of the strike this past March, 2020, thousands of women around Argentina and the world withheld their labor at work, school, and in the home. Marches and rallies planned in Buenos Aires even coincided with the fight for reproductive rights, as it has appeared recently that the legalization of abortion was imminent in Argentina. After a long struggle by activists, the elements of a strong movement aligned in favor of reforming the 1921 criminal code that allows a legal abortion only under very narrow circumstances. Scenes of the massive demonstrations outside Congress, made green bandanas synonymous with abortion reform and fueled a “Green Tide” not only in Argentina but across Latin America, leaving many to articulate a common loss for reproductive rights in Congress, but a win in the streets. The increasing inequalities exposed during the coronavirus pandemic have compounded social and political tensions, which were already on edge since the beginning of the protest movement. Forced to choose between their health and their livelihoods, some people have continued to protest in different forms regardless of the quarantine. Demonstrations in historically marginalized communities have denounced the lack of aid from the government, again connecting what seems like a singular reform to the need for larger democratic change. Communities in Chile are also organizing *ollas comunes* (soup kitchens) to feed themselves, as they did in the harshest years of economic crisis during the 20th century dictatorship. The community networks behind them—many of which emerged or were strengthened during the *estallido* (pandemic)—are also responding to the newest contingency by organizing trips to grocery stores and pharmacies for the elderly and patrols to accompany and support victims of domestic violence (NACLA May 2020).

Transnational feminist organizers have also taken up the struggle against debt as a banner of struggle as part of the dynamics of the feminist strike. Around the world, there have been calls such as: “We want ourselves alive and debt free!” (Argentina); “It is us against debt!” (Puerto Rico); “They owe us a Life!” (Chile); and “We don’t owe, we won’t pay!” (Spain). The feminist movement is politicizing, at the mass scale, issues of global finance, and it is a feminist analysis of debt that allows us to rethink economic violence in terms of its relationship with sexist violence. The feminist strike

in Latin America, which began by denouncing the debt with the International Monetary Fund and demonstrating its impact on household debts, calling debt a “historical mechanism of capitalism used to loot, exploit, and privatize the commons that we create and re-create, as well as to increase labor exploitation in moments of crisis.” This is, of course, a constant scene in Latin America: in the 1980s, debt disciplined the democratic transitions in the region following decades of dictatorship, and in the 1990s the Washington Consensus of neoliberal reforms pushed new thresholds of debt, while in recent years, we are witnessing a new relaunching of neoliberal financial colonization. Bolivia’s adoption of a new word, ‘depatriarchalization,’ clearly articulates the ways in which colonialism and patriarchy are intertwined to maintain debt and poverty throughout Latin America, and especially for the indigenous populations, but more clearly articulates efforts to undermine these structures in place.

Connecting debt, violence, and labor is a priority of the feminist strikes. In the call for this year’s international strike in Argentina, the discussion of debt is interwoven in different territories with a productive and reproductive strike expressed with the main feminist slogan: “The debt is owed to us, not the IMF or the churches,” demonstrating the movement’s broader horizon, a method of analysis and action that connects global financial regimes to individual experiences of debt and poverty.

Feminist organizers in the state of Hawaii have, in the past few decades, addressed gendered economic inequalities and implored the state to raise the minimum wage to a living wage (\$24.80/hour for single mothers), adopt universal basic income and single payer health care, and paid sick days and paid family leave. A recent feminist economic recovery plan by the Hawaii State Commission on the Status of Women (2020), has recently made use of the feminist political economic work of these Latin American feminist activists, marking it as a part of a larger transnational feminist movement. Articulating the state’s role in perpetuating gendered poverty, they are advocating for broad policies that eliminate cuts to social services, including services for domestic violence and for maternal, sexual, reproductive and mental health, and the coalition is still making recommendations to avoid government employee furlough wherever possible, as the public sector disproportionately employs women and people of color. The commission likewise urged creation of opportunities to allow existing government workers to participate in new roles within the recovery effort, rather than furloughing employees, coupled with free, safe and accessible childcare as soon as possible: “Caregiving, associated with and expected of women, is necessary for economic production to take place and yet it is split off from economic production, thereby structurally subordinating women in society. This is why even within their own racial, indigenous status, and economic groups, women are the most marginalized.” This represents the strength of transnational feminist movements, as the movements and issues move across borders and are articulated in other places that call out the violence of the state in ways that translate it for everyday organizing.

What transnational feminists have done is force us to move from an everyday politics of states and ‘actors’ and look at the movements themselves, directly connecting them to everyday lives. Transnational feminist movements can and should continue to be a crucial site for radical, collective social change. They strive to con-

tinue an intimate, collective and structural work from Chile to Hawaii, as they tackle global pandemics and networks, and make them both globally and locally relevant.

The grassroots construction of feminism as a transnational political movement is doing the on-the-ground work for the liberation of all gendered subjects and marginalized populations in ways that much feminist theory or policy in international development has not. Organizers and activists worldwide are, even amid a pandemic, working to connect and end the militarized domination of capitalism, from debt to gendered violence to labor.

One underlying problem with ‘international politics’ as we have come to understand it, is the lack of attention to transnational feminist organizing and its consistent effort for reshaping the globe. For all the fragmentation and division we speak of when we think of movements, there are also collective new alliances, new feminist knowledge and imaginings, and strategic engagements with and outside of global institutions that are already taking place. A feminist analysis (not just one that takes on the idea of women or the idea of gender) entails becoming committed to uncovering the implications of power of every gendered dynamic and social relation and interaction, not just highlighting the roles of women.

Mainstream policy work on international development is often dominated by theories and practices that focus on sustaining power structures as they are. Global feminist movements are often doing the opposite: opposing capital and the nation-state as given and articulating and imagining what a new, non-patriarchal, society could look like. As activists have reimagined possibilities, they have also changed what was once termed international politics to a globalized and transnational politics; what was once termed foreign policy now includes an understanding of the impact of continued processes of debt and sexist financial practices on our everyday lives. As Cynthia Enloe argues, theories of gender alone do not create more reliable global politics; rather, feminist consciousness must inform work on gender and politics as a whole. Feminists have moved the centers of power, to show how individuals and their communities, and especially their transnational movements, are in many ways central to understanding and opposing global power relations. There is much more to come.

Rachel O’Donnell teaches at the University of Rochester. She has written about the revolutionary forces during the Guatemalan civil war as well as the legacy of the Central American civil wars on development and policy in the region. She can be reached at rachel.odonnell@rochester.edu.

(See reference list on following page.)

“The production of ‘Third World women’ as the collective ‘Other’ through universal categories that position them as ‘poor, uneducated, tradition-bound, and victimised’ overlooks the complex and interconnected set of factors that produce ‘women’ as a category.”

— Awino Okech and Dinah Musindarwez

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Letter from Rose, niece of a local resident living in Portland, Oregon

Feeling pretty mentally fried at the moment – so forgive me if this is not super concise or coherent – but I wanted to share some general musings on what is currently happening in Portland. I’ve been a little hesitant to post firsthand accounts in the past months because protesters are being targeted by surveillance, and because I remain unsure whether centering my own experiences is constructive. However, as things continue to escalate, I think it is important for people to hear what is going on from trusted personal sources. (Especially those folks who still partially cling to the idea that police keep society safe.)

Despite the ‘violent mob’ narrative, the BLM protests in Portland have been deeply inspiring. I have been consistently moved by the wealth of resources and knowledge that people bring – from medics to de-escalation teams to ASL (American Sign Language) interpreters to folks providing food, protective equipment, and educational resources. The community continues to evolve and adapt. These gatherings have exemplified the beauty and efficacy of mutual aid and horizontal organization.

Calling protestors ‘violent’ while refusing to place that label on the cops who attack them night after night is misleading and harmful. Every single instance of physical violence against human beings that I have witnessed at these protests has been at the hands of the police. When the cops do not engage with protesters, people remain safe. Characterizing victims of police brutality as ‘criminal’ and ‘threatening’ in order to justify the exorbitant violence deployed against them is a framework deeply rooted in white supremacy. It is one of the ways the justice system has managed to maintain public complacency for decades as police disproportionately harass and murder Black civilians. This language has to stop. Please question the narrative and whom it serves.

The more recent presence of federal officers has dramatically escalated the violence that PPD was already perpetrating against protesters (and it should not be lost on anyone that those protesters are quite literally protesting police brutality and violence inflicted by systemic racism). In the past months I have experienced PPD officers repeatedly bull rushing and forcibly dispersing crowds (who posed absolutely no threat to public safety), assaulting protesters, and regularly deploying tear gas, stun grenades, mace, pepper balls, and rubber bullets. They have demonstrated time and time again that they are willing to label any form of civil disobedience as ‘violence’ in order to justify their own brutal/escalatory tactics. While the marches and gatherings that I have attended in parks and residential areas have had little to no police presence (and have therefore remained safe), any protest that is adjacent to a police precinct, courthouse, or union building has been unilaterally met with violence instigated by police (and now federal) officers. The nightly protests downtown are now regularly tear gassed to the point that a dense fog of CS gas spans multiple city blocks, and the powder builds up in clumps on the ground. The sensation of tear gas reacting with your eyes, face, throat, and lungs combined with the auditory backdrop of gunfire and grenade detonation, all while being pursued by a wall of cops in riot

gear, is disconcerting to say the least. Even leaving the protests feels fraught – at night, police cars (and now feds in rental cars) circle the neighborhoods surrounding the demonstrations downtown, and target anyone who looks like they have been protesting. Protest is integral to protecting human rights and ensuring healthy democracy, and should be protected as such. The local and federal responses are both telling and profoundly concerning.

The police have been increasingly flagrant in violently enforcing their own perceived absolute power. While I have to hope/believe that there will be repercussions for their actions, it is abundantly clear that the system is rigged in their favor. In late June, Gov. Kate Brown signed a law that banned tear gas except in situations that police declare to be a riot. Since then, the police have declared essentially any gathering they wish to disperse a ‘riot’ so that they can deploy tear gas. Reform doesn’t work if it is implemented by and at the discretion of the people that are being ‘reformed.’ In my eyes, any attempts at police reform are purely symbolic if the power structures that give cops authoritarian control remain in place. Reform without accountability is completely hollow. Our law enforcement system as it currently exists (and has always existed for that matter) is *far* beyond reform – there is an urgent need to reimagine what we as a society do to keep one another safe. Just because this is how it has been does *not* mean it is the only way forward.

The arsenal of physical weapons and psychological tactics being used against folks who are fighting for basic human rights shows how desperately both law enforcement and the federal government want to squash this movement. The police continue to frame protesters as some sort of violent career anarchists and vandals. They seek to obscure the fact that the crowds they are attacking are made up of concerned residents who have gathered to protest violence inflicted on Black communities by the police and the U.S. criminal justice system at large. Law enforcement doesn’t want to say the quiet part out loud: that what they are really – desperately, violently – protecting is their own power, which both upholds and is upheld by white supremacy at the core of their organization.

It is not lost on me that this is my first experience with police violence in 25 years of being alive, and that if I weren’t choosing to attend these protests I would have essentially no reason to fear for my safety in relation to the police. As a white person, and especially as a white cis woman, I recognize my life is deemed worthy of protection by the U.S. criminal justice system, even as I openly dissent. Many of the protesters who show up night after night do not have that layer of security, and I want folks to understand how much people are personally risking (both physically and psychologically) by showing up and fighting back. This is not a militant mob. Community members are risking everything despite immense vulnerability.

It is also worth *reiterating* that the police/feds are heedlessly using CS gas (which induces coughing, increased airway mucus production, and lasting breathing difficulty) in the midst of a pandemic spread by respiratory droplets. They force crowds into close quarters, preventing safe distancing. They do not protect or serve us, let’s not pretend otherwise.

So, I guess all this to say think critically, stay engaged, and do not let the current state of things limit your vision of a better future.

Introduction to *The Manifesto* & a reprint of abridged version of *Das Kapital*

BOB WEICK

In a café in Paris in 1844 two young, brilliant revolutionary thinkers met, spent ten days in spirited wine-soaked debate and formed a lifelong bond. A friendship that would last 40 years. Their body of brilliant economic and philosophical writings would inspire revolutions, shake the foundations of political economy, and thereby change the course of history.

Long since buried, and in certain circles dismissed as irrelevant, we have recently been experiencing a renewed interest in Marx and Engels. Karl Marx, it seems, with his studious critique of capitalism found in the voluminous *Das Kapital*, along with his co-author Friedrich Engels, and their clarion call for the revolutionizing of society in *The Communist Manifesto*, have returned from the grave.

The Communist Manifesto, published in 1848, is short and salty, with concepts and ideas immediately accessible. It was born in the midst of great societal upheaval. Kings and capitalists struggled to hold back the rising tide of communist political organizing. Indeed, the ruling classes saw clearly that “A spectre is haunting Europe. The spectre of communism.” These opening lines, this energetic claim, inspired those seeking freedom from the fetters of the bourgeoisie. It placed capitalism in a historical context. For those living in the tumult of the day and for generations to follow, it laid out in layman’s terms the battle that lay ahead, why it must be fought, and who must win. Engels conceded that Marx was the primary author, a “genius” and was content to play “second fiddle” to “so splendid a first fiddle.” Yet together they produced a concise pamphlet, remarkable for its grasp of the historic moment in which it was born. *The Manifesto* is the most widely read, if not the only work read, by many who engage with anti-capitalist revolutionary thought.

The publication of the first volume of *Das Kapital* in 1867, along with volumes two and three published posthumously by Engels, is another story. Unlike the *Manifesto*, it was not written for the general public. When trade unionist Peter Fox was handed a copy of *Das Kapital*, he lamented “I feel like a man who has just been given an elephant as a gift.” One has to agree. It is an elephant. Yet, it provided an in-depth analysis of the obscure and little understood inner workings of capitalism. *Das Kapital* is a scientific and technical analysis, albeit with several moments of poetic satire and wit. Written for the consumption of other philosophers, theorists, and economists, and to undergird the vanguard of the party, this work is often a challenge to read. Indeed, certain passages are almost as difficult to read as Marx’s famously indecipherable handwriting. (Handwriting of such dreadful penmanship that it had to be transcribed by his devoted wife Jenny before any work could be sent off to the printer.) The abridged version offered here is a godsend to those wanting to understand Marx’s political economy on a deeper level, but are not prepared to devote years of their lives to the effort.

Today, as then, Capitalism and Communism stand in binary oppositions to each other. In between these poles exists a variety of political and economic expression. So why this renewed interest in the philosophy of Karl Marx? Here in the United States neoliberal economic policies have failed to meet the needs and expectations of millions of people, yet with capitalism firmly ensconced in the halls of power, Marx's closing prediction in *The Communist Manifesto* that the ruling classes would "tremble" at the inevitable rise of communism seems a naive fantasy. His warning, a hollow threat, a laughable proclamation duly placed in the ash bin of history. Neoliberal democracies, the successful winners in this historic battle of ideologies, would come to rule and dominate the planet. However, across the globe, there are challenges to the status quo coming from both ends of the political spectrum. A terrifying rise of right-wing authoritarianism, nationalism, and neo-fascism, is met on the left with a resurgence of socialist organizing. Marx would likely point to the systemic injustices in our current economic mode of production as the reason for the rejection of the status quo. Just as millions lived in desperate poverty during the 1800's so too today, as rampant inequality soars to ever greater heights and as then, so too now, has undue influence in the halls of political power. Marx wrote in 1864 "To conquer political power has, therefore, become the duty of the working classes."

Marx's pointed comment in the *Manifesto* stating that "the executive of the modern state is but a committee for managing the common affairs of the whole bourgeoisie" rings true today. The inequality ever present in capitalist society was laid bare in their time, so too in ours. New challenges and questions arose then and arise now: Does society have to be this way? Where can we look for alternative ways for organizing our lives and work? Marx dares to answer these questions and many more in the book you now hold in your hands.

Born on May 5th, 1818 in the Western German city of Trier, Marx enjoyed a childhood of relative ease and economic security. His father Heinrich had converted to the Lutheran faith in order to enhance the viability of his law practice. It was not practical to be a Jew in Germany. It was assumed that young Karl would follow his father in the practice of law, but he was quickly drawn to philosophy and radical politics while being educated at the Universities of Bonn and Berlin. A member of the Young Hegelians and an eager follower of Hegel's famous dialectic which proposed that any existing reality, a thesis, is challenged by a competing thought, an "antithesis." This tension is then resolved by a synthesis of these competing ideas. At this point, a new thesis arises which is later challenged by a new antithesis, and then a new synthesis emerges and so on ad infinitum. The state of the world order was not fixed or pre-ordained but rather was in a constant process of change. In this exciting academic environment, he became involved in left-wing struggles which eventually led to his exile from Germany as well as other countries on the continent until at last he, his wife, and children landed in London in 1849 where he would live out his days. His remains rest at Highgate cemetery in London.

His life on Dean Street in the slums of the Soho neighborhood of London was one of recurring financial debt and privation. It was dismal setting in which Marx saw three of his children die; their deaths seemingly brought on by the frequent cold and damp of those two cramped rooms, along with periods of malnutrition. Scraping

out a meager living was a daily battle for the young philosopher's family. Without the support of Friedrich Engels, the family may not have survived at all.

Friedrich Engels, like Marx, was born into a prosperous family in the Rhineland region of Western Germany. His parents were devout Christians, and his father, a successful industrialist. Displaying a remarkable gift for literature, and languages, (he would later speak nine of them), his father nevertheless ended his education at the age of 17 and set him to work in the family business. Friedrich was soon to take control of his own education, eventually adopting atheism and like his good friend discovered and became a follower of Hegel. Inspired, as was Marx, by the notion that wrestling with contradictory opinions give rise to new ones. Yet, these philosophical pursuits were matched by a vigor and physical engagement with the world. At twenty-one, Engels was both a talented horseman, and a graceful dancer, but he left his cozy existence and joined the Army in 1841. "The General," as he came to be affectionately called, was delighted to be set free from his desk.

Yet his time spent among the working classes in Manchester deeply moved Engels. His experience led to his first great work *The Condition of the Working Class in England*.

No doubt Marx's personal experiences of poverty, along with his daily witness of the struggles of the working class in London and Engels's experience in his beloved Manchester, fed their dual passion for revolutionizing society. They theorized that a new world was possible. Marx proclaimed "In place of the old bourgeois society, with its classes and class antagonisms, we shall have an association, in which the free development of each is the condition for the free development of all." Capitalism inhibits this free development. Communism offered an end to this cycle of the dominance of one class and the corresponding submission of another. In the view of Marx and Engels and many of their closest companions, capitalism with its internal contradictions, its tendency to fall into cyclical crises, and its dehumanizing effects on the worker, was merely a stage in the historical development and had outlived its usefulness. The dialectical march of history had proclaimed its doom.

Marx took Hegel's dialectic and applied it to the history of economic systems. When Marx looked back through history, he saw that there had always been a ruling class and an exploited class. This application leads to one of his most famous conclusions in philosophy, "The history of all hitherto existing societies is the history of class struggle." He saw that these early systems of slavery and feudalism, like capitalism, had internal conflicts that led inevitably to their demise.

However, contrary to Marx's foundational premise of a constantly evolving society of "freely associated Men," subsequent iterations of his philosophy often misinterpreted his meaning and tragically, in the hands of some leaders, became dogmatic and totalitarian, in full rupture with Marx's dialectical foundation. Most often this abusive centralization of power and rigid dogmatism was a blood-soaked attempt to save a nascent revolution. The Machiavellian belief that the ends could justify the means of maintaining the revolution ran counter to Marx's insistence on consent as a first principle for organizing society.

As we have seen in the years since his death on March 14, 1883, attempts at forming communist states have drifted inexorably away from the foundational phil-

osophical understanding of Marx. In these instances, Marx's work has been misinterpreted and faultily applied, when not outright abandoned. These attempts also suffered mightily under capitalist forces bringing all their power in opposition. Yet, throughout the years many still held the red banner of revolution high and struggled to rescue Marx from the distortion of his fundamental philosophy. To this day, many across the globe continue championing the Marxist ideal of co-operation and workers' democracy in defiance. Many reinforce and build on his theory of freedom from alienation and exploitation. It's easy to extrapolate that Karl Marx himself would roundly condemn those dictatorial nations that wrongly called themselves communist.

Given the stratification and polarization present in society today the search for a better way to structure our economy has led to a resurgence of inquiry about Marx and socialism to such an extent that avowed socialist Bernie Sanders could not only run in the U.S. presidential primary but win entire States in the process. While Sanders is admittedly not a Marxist, his proud association with socialism indicates a tectonic shift in the political landscape. Clearly, the times have changed. Marx and socialism, at least to a significant portion of the American population, was once again worthy of discussion and consideration. In light of the political and economic realities in the United States the words of the Manifesto stating that "the history of all hitherto existing society is the history of class struggle" never seemed more relevant than where we find ourselves today. Marx theorized that the material circumstances of people's lives are fundamental to their perception and understanding of the world around them. The material challenges and the economic realities of life in western democracies at the start of the 21st century no doubt contribute to this renewed interest and awareness of Marxism. Conversely and more disturbingly to many, the precarious nature of the material lives of the typical worker has also led to explorations of right-wing ideology, authoritarianism, nationalism, and Nazism in response to the neoliberal failings.

The stages of development of the communist experiment, once full of hope and promise in the last half of the 19th century, empowered by the publication of the Manifesto and *Das Kapital*, devolved from a vision of the "dictatorship of the proletariat" of empowered workers, and the truly democratic expression of "freely associated men," to the centralization of power embodied in a cult figure, single party or central committee.

As we witness the rise of right-wing authoritarianism, with socialism no longer the dirty word it once was, with the crises of capitalism and its problematic results all around us, now is the perfect time to re-issue Marx's most famous works to meet the needs of the growing number of people drawn to its critical analysis and hopeful message. Rooted in the goal of liberation from the oppressive forces of colonialism, imperialism, and capitalism, at a time when right-wing reactionaries and authoritarianism is gaining popularity, Marx and socialism have been reborn in response. In this era of "post-truth," "fake news," rising inequality, and environmental destruction, alternatives must be found. Marx can contribute mightily to that search.

Has the war been lost, or is this conflict of ideas simply an ongoing historic battle? In the end will Karl Marx triumph over Adam Smith? Will a new synthesis come from the current divisions in American political and economic life? What will be the

history of economic evolution in the 21st century? Time will tell. Until then, let us all play our part in this historical moment. May this collection help your understanding, and inform your actions.

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Gabriel, Mary. Love and Capital. Boston: Little Brown, 2011

Marx, Karl. The Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844. New York: Prometheus Books, 1988

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Marx in Soho. Brooklyn: South End Press, 1999

Left Voice, for contemporary commentary and analysis from a Marxist perspective.



Is The New York Times Trying to Foster Working Class Consciousness?

GARY OLSON

There is only one thing the ruling circles have always wanted — and that's everything. —Michael Parenti

A recent lead editorial in *The New York Times* reads “Another Way the 2020s Might Be Like the 1930s.” Written by Jamelle Bouie, an African-American millennial (age 33) on the paper’s editorial staff, the piece contains the following opening and closing paragraphs:

“Class consciousness does not flow automatically out of class identity. Being a worker does not necessarily mean you will come to identify as a worker. Instead, you can think of class consciousness as a process of discovery, of insights derived from events that put the relationship of the class into stark relief.” After devoting most of what follows to empathic snapshots of recent worker strikes and protests Bouie concludes: “The militancy born of immediate self-protection and self-interest can grow into calls for deeper, broader transformation. And if the United States continues to stumble its way into yet another generational-defining economic catastrophe, we may find that even more of the working class comes to see itself as an agent of change — and action.”

The piece seemed far outside the *NYT*’s semi-official propagandizing fare. Were the editors inadvertently aiding and abetting capitalist class suicide? Realizing that this was an a priori impossibility and reflecting further, I could fathom a similar piece appearing in the paper in the early 1930s. Indeed, I found a cartoon in the *Times* from 1933 that expressed confidence in a newly-elected President Franklin Delano Roosevelt.

At that time, economic conditions and organized, radical pressure from below, threatened to delegitimize the ideological and structural foundations of capitalism. Fearing that an emerging working-class consciousness might lead to a revolution, Bouie-like liberal reformers of the day tried to persuade the predator class to change their greedy ways before it was too late. Because they failed, FDR publicly accused fellow members of his class of being “stubborn and incompetent... they have no vision.” He and the Democratic Congress then launched a raft of reforms in a conscious effort to save capitalism while simultaneously neutering working-class militancy. In doing so, FDR solemnly pledged this was all “entirely feasible under the form of government we have inherited from our ancestors.”

Here it’s worth noting that considerable uncertainty remains about just how comfortable FDR, previously a conventional liberal politician, was about his own



Photos: U.S. National Textile Workers' Strikers facing off against National Guardsmen and Federal troops in 1934. At its peak there were more than 400,000 on strike across the country.

far-reaching reforms. One piece of evidence casting doubt on his commitment was that in 1937-38, perhaps believing that the two emergencies cited earlier had been blunted, FDR sought a balanced budget, severely reduced the Federal fiscal stimulus and reduced taxes, all of which collapsed the economy again and quickly sent unemployment figures into the high teens, a period dubbed the “Roosevelt Recession.”

With World War II looming, FDR turned away from the New Deal, scuttled national health care, tied welfare to work and championed free trade. We’ll never know what might have happened next because massive deficit spending on World War II saved the capitalist economy. I rarely agree with Paul Krugman but he’s correct in saying that “Even under FDR, there never was sufficient will to do what was necessary to end the Great Depression; it’s eventual resolution came essentially by accident.” Deficit spending on the war was the equivalent of \$30 trillion in today’s dollars.

All of the above bears directly upon Bouie’s column. In an earlier opinion piece, he praised Bernie Sanders as his favorite candidate to undertake needed liberal reforms, just weeks before Sanders ended his presidential campaign and endorsed Joe Biden. In another column, he urged Democrats to seize the moment and enact “New Dealish” policies and programs. What’s transparent in Bouie’s narrow view of class consciousness, he confuses it with an embryonic stage when working men and women arrive at something commonly understood as trade-union consciousness (TUC). All too often this is its terminal stage and that’s not by accident. When conservative AFL founder Samuel Gompers was asked by nervous U.S. Senators — who were fretting about socialists in the labor movement — what his members wanted, he replied “More!” His response put the Senator’s fears to rest as they immediately envisioned channeling worker unrest into safer outlets.

Recognizing the need for unions is an essential but insufficient step on the path to class consciousness. While mitigating some inequities, unions themselves do not fundamentally transform the relationship between owners and workers. By contrast, mature class consciousness is nothing less than when the objective, general, and rational interests of a class become its recognized goals. It would be captured in a statement like, “I’m a worker, exploited by the capitalist class. Our collective working-class goals cannot be realized without overthrowing the exploitive capitalist class relations that prevent us from getting what we want and need.”

By only favoring TUC, Bouie and *The New York Times* reveal that capitalist system-maintenance are the motives behind their importations for action. They are encouraging union officials to get out of bed with the bosses, “essential” workers to realize their importance in the economy, Congress to take bold action and at least implicitly, VOTE BLUE! And that’s all. In promoting reforms to prevent the transition from economic demands to class struggle, capitalists and their enablers demonstrate why they are the most class-conscious group in the United States. It’s a strategy we can expect to see deployed more in the near future.

Today, the recourse of relying on politics within a democratic system that isn’t democratic is a fool’s errand. Likewise, the Democrats, who are part of the oligarchical establishment, have no interest in the working class other than obtaining their votes. Beyond that, the Lords of Capital and their enablers have rigged the system, making it virtually impossible for third parties to succeed.

Our rulers are now panicking about the possibility of wildcat strike waves, radical organizing, and sustained, massive non-violent civil disobedience by those who, like MLK’s followers, are unafraid of arrest and knew, along with Frederick Douglas, that “Power concedes nothing without a struggle. It never did and it never will.” Given their overwhelming numbers, if these self-emancipatory actions emerge out of genuine working-class consciousness, the state’s enforcement powers will be helpless to stop them. Neither will they be co-opted because — to recast Parenti’s opening quote — there is only one thing that those wanting radical change have ever wanted in terms of economic and political democracy — and that’s everything.

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We develop new principles for the world out of the world’s own principles. We do not say to the world: Cease your struggles, they are foolish; we will give you the true slogan of struggle. We merely show the world what it is really fighting for, and consciousness is something that it has to acquire, even if it does not want to.

—Karl Marx (1843)

May Day History: The Haymarket Riot

LENNY FLANK

In the early United States, labor unions were outlawed—they were considered to be illegal conspiracies in restraint of “free trade.” That changed in 1842, when, in the Hunt case, the courts ruled that collective bargaining was legal and that workers could form unions and associations. At first, labor unions were small, weak, and rarely extended beyond the employees of one company. Most workers continued to be paid starvation wages, for which they worked as much as 12 hours a day, sometimes seven days a week. But as economic conditions for labor worsened after the Civil War (and the financial Panic of 1873 caused economic chaos), American workers became more militant. When the 1877 national railroad strike broke out and paralyzed the entire country, no labor union had organized or led it—the strike had grown spontaneously from the railroad workers themselves. Over 100 strikers were killed in street battles across the country as President Rutherford B Hayes sent in State and Federal troops to crush the strike. In response, workers in all industries began to organize, first with the Knights of Labor and then with the Federation of Organized Trades and Labor Unions, which would later change its name to the American Federation of Labor.

In 1882, the Federation called for an all-out campaign of nationwide protest actions to win a law enforcing an eight-hour working day. To allow enough time for organizing and educational agitation, the starting date for this national campaign was set for May 1, 1884. On the appointed day, huge rallies and protest marches were held in every major city in the U.S.. And the largest May Day demonstration happened in the leading industrial city of the U.S.—Chicago. Over 80,000 of the city’s workers marched up Michigan Avenue with signs that read “8 Hours for work, 8 hours for rest, 8 hours for what we will!” and “Shorter hours increases the pay!”

Chicago’s local labor movement was dominated by radical Socialists and Anarchists. Two of the organizers of the May Day march had been Albert Parsons, a printer by trade who edited the local anarchist newspaper *The Alarm*, and his wife Lucy, a Mexican/African-American who had been born a slave in Texas. Chicago was the economic focus of the United States—a railroad hub and the focus of the meatpacking industry, and a center of construction and manufacturing. And, in response, Chicago also had the strongest, best-organized, and most militant labor movement in the country.

Two days after the May Day march for the 8-hour day, a crowd of protesters gathered at Chicago’s McCormick Reaper plant, where workers had been on strike since February. During a speech by local anarchist August Spies, Chicago police, perhaps shaken by the size of the previous rally and march and fearing another mass demonstration, opened fire on the unarmed strikers, killing two.

In response to this shooting, local labor groups and anarchists met that night and planned a protest rally for the next evening, May 4, in Haymarket Square in the center of Chicago. The group obtained a permit for the rally, lined up a number

of speakers, and printed pamphlets to distribute. The first printed flyers contained the headline “Workingmen Arm Yourselves and Appear in Full Force!”, but several of the planned speakers, including the anarchist August Spies, said they would not appear if the leaflets advocated violence. The leaflets were destroyed, and a new batch was printed with a different headline.

Word had already gotten around, however, that there might be trouble at the protest (after all, police had already shot strikers the day before). As a result, only 2,500 people showed up at the Haymarket rally on the evening of May 4. Several speakers also failed to appear, which delayed the rally by an hour until two last-minute replacement speakers—Albert Parsons, who had just returned from a rally in Ohio, and Samuel Fielden, a local minister who was involved in labor organizing—were recruited and rushed to the scene. They spoke from a flatbed wagon that had been set up near an alleyway at one end of Haymarket Square.

By 10:30 pm, it was dark and beginning to drizzle, and the crowd had already thinned to less than 300 as the last speaker, Fielden, mounted the wagon. As he spoke, the police arrived, led by Inspector John Bonfield, and some 200 officers formed up in phalanx. Bonfield ordered the crowd to disperse—Fielden responded with “We are a peaceable assembly.” At that moment, someone (it was never established who) threw a homemade dynamite bomb into the police ranks. The explosion killed one officer and wounded a dozen more. In response, the police opened fire, killing four protesters. Six policemen died later from wounds, and some sixty more police were wounded, many of them likely shot in the confusion by their own fellow officers. It is not known how many protesters were wounded.

The “Haymarket Riot” set off a storm not only in Chicago, but across the country. Martial law was declared in Chicago, and police raids were launched to shut down union halls and labor newspapers and arrest most of Chicago’s labor leaders. In particular, the anarchists were targeted, and virtually every well-known anarchist in Chicago was arrested. Eventually, the police filed charges against eight defendants: Albert Parsons and Samuel Fielden had spoken at the Haymarket rally. August Spies was also a speaker at the rally and the editor of the local anarchist newspaper *Arbeiter-Zeitung*; when the newspaper’s office was raided, assistant editor Michael Schwab and typesetter Adolph Fischer were also arrested. Oscar Neebe was a writer for the *Arbeiter*—he was arrested later. Local anarchist Louis Lingg was found with bomb-making materials in his apartment (though no one could connect him to the bomb which was thrown at the rally, and Lingg himself wasn’t at Haymarket that night). And local anarchist speaker George Engel was the final defendant. Of the eight, only two were actually in Haymarket Square when the bomb went off—speakers Fielden and Spies. Two others, Parsons and Schwab, were there earlier but left for a nearby bar after Parsons finished his speech. Neebe was giving a speech in another town at the time; Engel was home playing cards. A ninth person, local anarchist Rudolf Schnaubelt, was suspected by police of being the actual bomb-thrower, but he had already fled the country. Parsons was indicted but had also left the area and was not initially arrested, but voluntarily surrendered to police just before the trial began, and took his place in the docket. Although the police could not tie any of the eight defendants to the actual bomb, they were all charged with conspiring to commit the

bombing, on the grounds that by encouraging violent revolution in their speeches and writings, they had motivated the bomber, whoever he was, to act. Their real crime, of course, was being anarchists, union organizers, and political radicals.

The jury selection took three weeks. Anyone who showed sympathy for unions, socialism or radicalism was dismissed by the judge, while jurors who expressed distaste for radicalism or anarchism were allowed as long as they declared they would be impartial. The defense used up all its peremptory challenges, and the jury was packed with anti-union and anti-anarchist citizens. Over the next two months, the prosecution presented 118 witnesses — none of whom could place any of the defendants there with a bomb or could establish any connection to the actual bombing. Instead, the prosecution argued that simply by being anarchists, the defendants had conspired to commit violence. On August 20, the jury convicted all 8 defendants, and sentenced seven of them to death (the eighth, Neebe, received a sentence of 15 years).

The trial, meanwhile, had become the focus of international protest. Labor unions, socialists and anarchists around the world condemned the charges as simple repression of radicals, and dismissed the proceedings as a mere show trial with a predetermined end. Telegrams flooded into the White House and the Governor's office demanding clemency or a pardon. On November 10, 1887, Governor Richard Oglesby, citing the lack of evidence that they were involved in the bombing, commuted the sentences of Fielden and Schwab to life in prison. Later that night, Lingg killed himself in prison using a blasting cap that had been smuggled in to him. The next day, Spies, Parsons, Engel and Fischer were all hanged. They are still known as “The Haymarket Martyrs”.

On June 26, 1893, new Illinois Governor Altgeld signed an order releasing Fielden, Schwab and Neebe from prison, and retroactively pardoning the five dead Haymarket defendants. Altgeld concluded that the trial had been unfair and unjust, noting that the prosecution “never discovered who it was that threw the bomb which killed the policeman, and the evidence does not show any connection whatsoever between the defendants and the man who threw it,” and that the defendants had been the victims of “hysteria, packed juries, and a biased judge.”

In July 1889, at a convention of labor unions in Paris, delegates from the American Federation of Labor proposed that May 1st, the date of the original 8-hour day campaign that led to the execution of the Haymarket Martyrs, be declared “International Labor Day.” The proposal was adopted unanimously. Since that time, May Day has been celebrated as Labor Day (usually as an official state holiday) in every industrialized country in the world from Mexico to Japan to Australia, except one. In 1894, the United States officially set the first Monday in September, not May 1st, as “Labor Day.” The U.S. Department of Labor's website manages to give several pages on the “history of Labor Day” without once mentioning the word “Haymarket.”

As for May Day in the U.S.: when the Soviet Union was established in 1917, it immediately joined the rest of the civilized world (well, except for the U.S.) in setting May Day as a national holiday. Over the years, though, as the Cold War grew, “May Day” in the Soviet Union became an exercise in military showmanship, as tons of tanks and missiles were paraded through Red Square to demonstrate the strength of the “Socialist Paradise”. Labor movements in most countries just ignored the Soviet

silliness. But in the United States, the Soviets could not be allowed to compete even in holidays, and so in 1958, at the height of the Cold War, the U.S. declared May 1st to be “Law Day”, a day, President Eisenhower proclaimed, when Americans would rededicate themselves to “the ideals of equality and justice under law in their relations with each other and with other countries.”

Lenny is a longtime labor organizer and environmental, social, and antiwar activist. He was a founder of the Lehigh Valley IWW in the early 1990s.



This 1886 engraving depicts the Haymarket Affair

They Helped Destroy Mussolini!

ANNE COLAMOSCA

In 2020 the rising angst against a resurgent fascism took on an urgency not seen for a century. In the U.S., Brazil, Hungary, India and Italy, fascism was appearing in various forms, all of them profoundly worrying. And in some of these countries, a familiar angry cry went up: “Antifa!” One hundred years earlier—where fascism first appeared, that same chant rang out in most northern cities of Italy in postwar anger. Great War veterans were disenchanted, angry, disabled and broke. Many promises had been made to them. None were kept. They came to be known as “fasci.” They were supported financially in many local clubs by those who were afraid of a rising leftist tide. Retired military officers, local police, and agents of landowners and industrialists stood behind the “fasci.” The antifa were most often union members who worked at northern factories pushing for higher wages and better conditions. In 1920, the “biennio rosso,” two ‘red years’ of occupation and strikes, had raised hopes of the antifa.

But the fascists coalesced quickly in response and their physical brutality was immediate. A “warm-up” session had occurred in the city of Fiume, adjacent to Slovenia. Gabriele D’Annunzio, a middle-aged, cocaine-fueled writer and aviator led a 1,000-man paramilitary operation into Fiume in 1919. Political leaders at the Treaty of Versailles decided against giving Fiume to Italy as they had vaguely promised. D’Annunzio’s men stayed for over a year, “setting the stage for an extraordinary drama...one in which some of the darkest themes of the next half-century’s history were announced,” wrote Lucy Hughes Hallett, author of *Gabriele D’Annunzio: Poet, Seducer, and Preacher of War*.

“The fascists were not really Mussolini’s creation,” explained the noted Italian historian Gaetano Salvemini in his 1927 book, *The Fascist Dictatorship in Italy*. “The local groups prepared the fasci veterans. The military armed and drilled them. The big war profiteers subsidized them. The police and the magistrates assured them of impunity.” Within months, in 1921, the Fascist Party was born and by 1922 Mussolini had taken over the Italian government in a rapid coup d’état.

Mussolini would quickly replace an aging and ill D’Annunzio. A well-known speaker and newspaper editor who had moved from socialism to fascism, Mussolini was a gifted public relations man, convincing many public intellectuals such as Winston Churchill that Fascism was a gift to Italy. From the beginning, though, Mussolini picked up where D’Annunzio had left off—with unspeakable violence against the left. By 1924, the fascists were so confident that they kidnapped and murdered a popular socialist deputy, Giacomo Matteotti. He had bravely spoken out against Mussolini who sat at the back of the Parliament hall. Matteotti’s death was a calamitous defining moment for leading anti-fascists, according to Salvemini. They had been conflicted by internal fighting and were totally unprepared for the rapid takeover of the fascists.

It would be 21 years under fascism before a coalition of top military men backed by the Italian monarch, toppled Mussolini on July 25, 1943. The Germans would immediately set up Mussolini in a “rump” government in the north until he was eventually captured and killed by the Italian Resistance movement, made up of a range of leftwing soldiers, the majority being communists. Allied commanders would attest to the fact that the Resistance movement had helped them tremendously, actually substantially shortening the war against the Nazis taking place between 1943 and 1945.

And when the war finally ended, many antifascists returned to Italy after many years in exile. Among the most high-profile were Gaetano Salvemini; world-famous novelist and socialist, Ignazio Silone; and Italian Communist party chief Palmiro Togliatti. Their transition to life in Italy after World War II was often dramatic, disappointing and unexpected. The trio had devoted much of their lives—even in exile—to saving Italy from the fascists. What they discovered on their return was a totally reordered political landscape—led no longer by the fascists, but the Americans, intent on imposing their will on this country which they had fought to free from the Nazis and which had a two million strong Communist party, directed from Moscow, putting Italy at the vortex of the newly emerging Cold War. The Christian Democrat Party, backed and financially supported by the Americans, emerged as the major political force, buoyed by the Catholic Church, the Italian right, and both the Truman and Eisenhower administrations.

Italy had only been unified as a country for fifty years—since 1870, compared to the 250-year history of the United States, with its often cumbersome rules of checks and balances. In the era of Donald Trump, though, those checks—especially because of the Supreme Court, were prohibiting him from sliding into an even deeper authoritarianism than he had already moved the country into as he closed into four years of being in office. The three high-profile anti-fascists—Togliatti, Salvemini and Silone—as hard as they had tried, had no control over the physical assaults, arson and murders committed by the Fascists very early into Mussolini’s dictatorship. And in 2020, a spate of physical assaults throughout the U.S. had awakened fears of encroaching fascism. There was an anguishing increase in violence as the Trump era progressed. Cars racing down avenues murdering demonstrators in unrepentant rages, local police hanging out with alt-right groups, Ku Klux Klansmen returning to their old haunts in southern towns that did reawaken Fascist horrors of a century ago.

Palmiro Togliatti

Togliatti had spent much of his exile in Moscow as a key Comintern member, managing to survive Stalin’s bloody purges year after year. Yet he bucked Comintern policy in one ongoing way. Despite Stalin’s anger, Togliatti would always insist that Italy had a unique political trajectory: “The Italian Road to Socialism,” that would lead to some model of socialism that was less austere than that imposed on eastern European countries. At the same time, Togliatti, known as “Stalin’s man,” would carry out some of Stalin’s “darker” assignments, including shooting rival POUM leftists in the Spanish Civil War, a scenario that George Orwell dramatically describes in his book *Homage to Catalonia*. “They (the PCI) remained ardent communists,” explains Joan Barth Urban in her critically acclaimed book, *Moscow and the Italian Communist Party*, “working within a movement brutalized by Stalin.”

Togliatti had made it through law school as a scholarship student, graduating from the prestigious University of Turin, as a lawyer. He, along with academic Antonio Gramsci and the audacious recent high school graduate, Silone (leader of the youth movement), would form the Italian Communist Party, or the PCI. When Gramsci was imprisoned in 1927 by Mussolini, Togliatti would become general secretary of the party, holding that job for four decades until he died in 1964. He would become known in Italy for his conciliatory stance towards the Christian Democrats, angering many on the left. Each conciliatory move seemed to consolidate the Christian Democrats, and after a very short time as part of a coalition government just after the war, the socialists and communists were expelled from the new government formed in 1947. The following year, 1948, things became worse, when the newly formed CIA on “its maiden voyage” interfered in a massive way in the Italian national election, buying votes for a Christian Democrat win by using mafia members to distribute large sums of money to buy votes. When Togliatti was shot after the election, he solemnly directed his party members not to take up arms. Many thought an Italian civil war could have easily broken out at this time.

Compounding the problem, the American foreign policy establishment, in both administrations, concentrated on eradicating the communists, leaving the fascists in place. Italy had no Nuremberg trials or Truth and Reconciliation committees. Many returned leftists found they were immediately fired by fascist bosses only too happy to get rid of them. And, as University of Florence historian Paul Ginsborg points out in his classic, *A History of Contemporary Italy: Society and Politics 1943-1988*, “Togliatti was minister of Justice from June, 1945 to October 1946. During his tenure... he made no serious effort whatsoever to reform the judiciary or purge it of its fascist elements.” “If there is a single, recurrent, almost obsessive theme in the political history of postwar Italy,” adds Ginsborg, “it is that of the need for reform and of the failure to achieve it.... [T]he years from 1943 to 1945... offered possibilities that were unrepeatable.” Workers suffered repressed wages, poor housing, and poverty in general. Cold War policies in the first part of the 1950s were especially repressive as Americans signaled that the industrial unions with legions of communist members had to be broken and financial assistance was withheld if this goal was not realized. Even in an internationally touted Italian miracle in the 1950s, wages were repressed, producing long years of cheap labor to make that “miracle” possible.

Gaetano Salvemini

Salvemini returned to Italy in 1947 after living first in Europe and then teaching at Harvard for 14 years. He was always seen as a particularly gifted and committed teacher. He began his first lecture back at the University of Florence in a gentle, teasing way by saying, “as I was saying in the last lecture....” But by this time he was 74 years old. He taught for a few years, spoke out aggressively against American interventionism and ultimately retired to Sorrento, in constant touch with many anti-fascists until his death in 1957. He had done much for the antifascist cause, publishing a second book while at Harvard, *Under the Axe of Fascism*, a scathing account of what the “economic miracle” was actually like for workers, and a derisive segue into Mussolini’s egotistical foray into Ethiopia to divert world attention from Italian domestic woes. In the mid 1920s, Salvemini had been imprisoned, sent to court in an

iron cage where he was described by a friend as “big, hirsute, with his wild gray beard covering most of his face, pacing up and down, cheerful, chatting, reminding people of a bear on a chain.” Amazingly, the judge acquitted him. He escaped a group of blackshirts outside and made it to Europe. His lecture room had been haunted daily by blackshirts with truncheons shouting, “The Ape of Molfatta!” while students tried to protect him. He said during those days he never knew if he would make it out alive after his classes.

Ignazio Silone

Ignazio Silone, one of Salvemini’s many long-term friends gave the major eulogy at Salvemini’s funeral in 1957. The two were unusual—both having been born in small southern villages of very modest means. Most socialist leaders at the time hailed from the north and were fairly well-to-do. Silone would speak fondly of his fellow “cafoni,” a somewhat derogatory term for peasant. Both men had suffered devastating personal losses in two separate earthquakes—Silone losing his beloved mother, Salvemini losing his wife and five children. Silone would write afterwards that what surprised him “was the matter-of-factness with which the townspeople seemed to accept the catastrophe.” “It was this eternal resignation that Silone found hard to bear,” writes Stanislaw Pugliese in his brilliant, prize-winning biography, *Bitter Spring: A Life of Ignazio Silone*. Silone’s mother had been a weaver and he had grown up very close to her and his grandmother. As Pugliese explains, “he listened with fascination to the stories and later likened the art of storytelling to weaving....[H]e would write that ‘the mountains, the fables that the peasants lived by, their deep stubbornness and sudden thrusts of integrity,’ was embedded in his deep memory of his village Pescina dei marsi.”

Later, in Moscow, meeting with the leaders of the Russian revolution—Silone would get disgusted at their insistence on patronizing the communist Italians, while knowing nothing about Italian politics themselves. He would later write that they would never tolerate anyone with a different point of view. “Silone refused to be cowed by the prestige of the Russians,” writes Pugliese. “When Lenin took to the podium to criticize the Italians, Silone...defending his colleagues...was called to task by Trotsky.” In 1927, Silone refused Stalin’s order to condemn Trotsky at the historic meeting in which Trotsky was denounced and banned. Silone would be expelled from the Communist Party in 1931. He would write that “it was a very sad day for me, a day of mourning. I was once a communist; I am not ashamed of it.” He insisted that “Marx had gained entrance to the pantheon of modern thinkers who have transformed our consciousness....[N]o one could argue that Marxism was not a necessary tool for a proper understanding of the world; no one could escape Marx’s influence.” Yet he had come to see Soviet communism as just another form of totalitarianism. Importantly, Silone did not move to the political right as was common in those days among ex-communists such as Arthur Koestler. He remained, until his death, a nominal socialist. As he expressed it, “a socialist without a party, a Christian without a church.”

Silone’s life would take a totally unexpected, iconoclastic turn in the early 1930s when he moved to Zurich, Switzerland, ill, broke and deeply depressed. He became involved with the circle around the psychologist Carl Jung and found, amazingly in Jung’s work, an answer to his own questions surrounding his birthplace, politics

and Italy's destiny. It involved Jung's work involving "archetype," that not only a person, but a nation such as Italy had to be true to its own essence, not something alien imposed on it. Jung had written that the ultimate aim of every individual was to achieve a state of selfhood... and he argued that "many of the problems of modern life are caused by man's progressive alienation from his instinctual foundation."

So, Silone returned psychologically to Pescina, and amazingly produced what would become his world-famous "exile trilogy," three books: *Fontamara*, *Bread and Wine*, and *The Seed Beneath the Snow*. Trotsky wrote, "From the first to the last line *Fontamara* is directed against the Fascist regime in Italy, its acts of violence, and its atrocities.... [I]n it, the revolutionary passion is raised to such a height that it becomes a work of art." Others wrote that Silone's trilogy was the most powerful and influential work of antifascist literature of the 1930s. "Look at Silone," wrote Albert Camus, "he is radically tied to his land but is the most European of writers.... Silone speaks to all of Europe." And William Faulkner thought Silone was Italy's greatest living writer, as writers, comments Pugliese, "as diverse as Thomas Mann, Graham Greene and Edmund Wilson agreed." And Silone would benefit greatly in the early 21st century when Pugliese, a biographer who wrote important historical narrative and was somehow able to intuit his totally remarkable transformation in Zurich, would explain his psychological transformation with Jungian help. "Benedictine and Franciscan monks, hermits, apocalyptic orators, visionaries and alms seekers wandered the countryside (in Pescina). Local fables stressed the deep mysticism and frail humanity of believers," wrote Pugliese. Silone would explain his deep feeling about a "primitive Christianity," based on a wholly different concept of socialism involving the peasant, Jesus and his teachings about poverty, misery and suffering."

But things were vastly different for Silone when he returned to Italy in the mid 1940s and began living in Rome. Literary critic Alfred Kazin would comment, "You couldn't find Silone's books anywhere," explaining that every Italian literary critic he met "goes out of his way to disparage Silone." It was said that Silone didn't write 'proper Italian,' and that his subject matter—the rural Abruzzo peasant wasn't a fit literary subject. And Silone would respond years later, saying that this criticism was due to the fact that many in the literary establishment had been fascists and hated his critics. But he had many other enemies: the Communists still disliked him for dissenting from the Russian revolutionaries; the Americans were annoyed because he helped out the OSS during the war to fight the Nazis, but that he had instantly resigned when told that the CIA had been financing his newspaper; and the socialists were furious when he did everything in his power to ruin a proposed merger with the Italian communists as soon as he returned from exile.

Interestingly, Salvemini and Silone—with vastly different life experiences as adults—ended up politically in much the same place. As they both aged—they were nominal socialists, no longer wanting to be involved in party work, but both using their immensely powerful professional platforms to influence situations whenever they could. Silone had served in the Italian parliament for two years from Abruzzo from 1946-48 and was able to help craft a new constitution and vote to make Italy a republic and oust the monarchy. But after one term, he resigned, claiming that the "pettiness, venality and corruption of the postwar period sent him into serious

despondency." And, of course, American intervention in that election, and many others to come, would ensure that Christian Democrats would stay in power for many years. The antifascists had worked incredibly hard to rid themselves of Mussolini, using all of their own individual gifts, but found themselves perennially in the locked jaws of the insidious Cold War.

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Editor's Note: The little-known background to Anne Colamosca's article is the successful CIA intervention in the Italian elections of April 1948. Indeed, CIA election operations are the oldest trick in the tool box of the agency dating back to its founding in 1947 with the National Security Act. The CIA's Italian election operations were likely its very first significant election operation. President Truman's National Security Council, which was established by the same National Security Act, immediately set about to tackle the question of the Italian elections and proceeded to set aside a large sum of \$10 million for secret CIA intervention in those elections with the aim of securing a victory for the Christian Democrats and defeating the coalition of socialists and communists who had been the backbone of the anti-fascist resistance during the Mussolini years. The agency continued to support the Christian Democrats with on average \$5 million per year into the 1960s.¹

*"Fascism was a counter-revolution against
a revolution that never took place."*

—Ignazio Silone, Italian author

¹ nsarchive.gwu.edu/briefing-book/intelligence/2017-02-07/cia-covert-aid-italy-averaged-5-million-annually-late-1940s

We Are All Jakarta

A REVIEW BY DAVID SWANSON

Vincent Bevins. *The Jakarta Method: Washington's Anticommunist Crusade and the Mass Murder Program that Shaped Our World*. Public Affairs (May 19, 2020). Hardcover, \$28 (320p) ISBN: 978-1541742406

The war on Vietnam plays an infinitely larger role in history in the common understanding of a typical U.S. citizen than does what the U.S. government did to Indonesia in 1965-1966. But if you read *The Jakarta Method*, the new book by Vincent Bevins, you will have to wonder what moral basis there can possibly be for that fact.

During the war on Vietnam a tiny fraction of the casualties were members of the U.S. military. During the overthrow of Indonesia, zero percent of the casualties were members of the U.S. military. The war on Vietnam may have killed some 3.8 million people, not counting those who would die later from environmental poisoning or war-induced suicide, and not counting Laos or Cambodia. The overthrow of Indonesia may have killed some 1 million people. But let's look a bit further.

The war on Vietnam was a failure for the U.S. military. The overthrow in Indonesia was a success. The former changed little in the world. The latter was critical in destroying the non-aligned movement of third-world governments, and in establishing a policy of quietly “disappearing” and torturing and slaughtering huge numbers of left-leaning civilians all over the globe. That policy was taken by U.S. officials from Indonesia to Latin America and used to establish Operation Condor and a wider global network of U.S.-led and U.S.-supported mass-murder operations.

The Jakarta method was used in Argentina, Bolivia, Brazil, Chile, Paraguay, and Uruguay in the 1970s and 1980s, to the tune of 60,000 to 80,000 people murdered. The same tool was taken into Vietnam in 1968-1972 under the name Operation Phoenix (50,000 killed), Iraq 1963 and 1978 (5,000 killed), Mexico 1965-1982 (1,300 killed), the Philippines 1972-1986 (3,250 killed), Thailand 1973 (3,000 killed), Sudan 1971 (fewer than 100 killed), East Timor 1975-1999 (300,000 killed), Nicaragua 1979-1989 (50,000 killed), El Salvador 1979-1992 (75,000 killed), Honduras 1980-1993 (200 killed), Colombia 1985-1995 (3,000-5,000 killed), plus some places where similar methods had been begun already, such as Taiwan 1947 (10,000 killed), South Korea 1948-1950 (100,000 to 200,000 killed), Guatemala 1954-1996 (200,000 killed), and Venezuela 1959-1970 (500-1,500 killed).

These are Bevins' numbers, but the list is hardly exhaustive, and the full impact can't be understood without recognizing the extent to which this was known around the world outside of the United States, and the degree to which this murder spree made the mere threat of further killing decisive in influencing governments toward policies that harmed their people — not to mention the resentment and blowback produced. I just interviewed John Perkins, author of *Confessions of an Economic Hitman*, on Talk Nation Radio, about his new book, and when I asked him how many coups

had been accomplished without any coup being needed, simply with a threat, his answer was “countless.”

The Jakarta Method makes clear some basic points that popular conceptions of history get wrong. The Cold War was not won, capitalism was not spread, the U.S. sphere of influence was not enlarged just by example or even by Hollywood promotion of something desirable, but also significantly by murdering masses of men, women, and children with dark skin in poor countries without getting U.S. troops killed which might have caused someone to start caring. The secretive, cynical CIA and alphabet soup of unaccountable agencies accomplished almost nothing over the years through spying and snooping — in fact those efforts were almost always counterproductive on their own terms. The tools that overthrew governments and imposed corporate policies and sucked out profits and raw materials and cheap labor were not just propaganda tools and not just the carrots of aid to brutal dictators, but also, perhaps first and foremost: the machete, the rope, the gun, the bomb, and the electric wire.

The murder campaign in Indonesia did not have a magical origin out of nowhere, though it was new in its scale and in its success. And it did not depend on a single decision in the White House, though the transfer of power from JFK to LBJ was critical. The United States had been preparing Indonesian soldiers in the United States for years, and arming the Indonesian military for years. The U.S. took a peacefully minded ambassador out of Indonesia and put in one who had been part of a brutal coup in South Korea. The CIA had its new leader of Indonesia picked out well in advance, as well as long lists of “communists” who should be murdered. And so they were. Bevins notes that U.S. officials had already supplied similar murder lists in Guatemala 1954 and Iraq 1963. I suspect South Korea 1949-1950 may belong in that list as well.

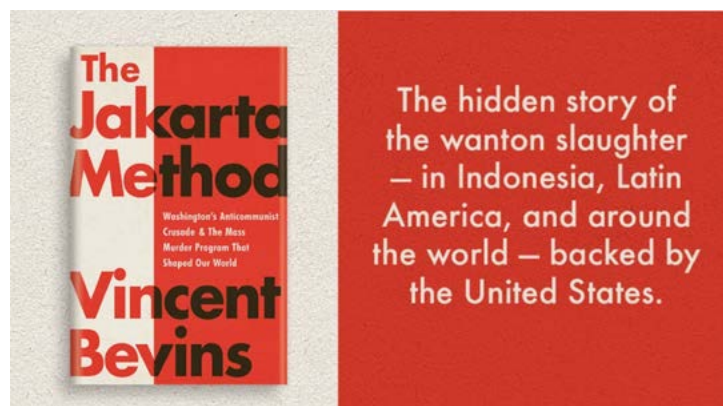
The overthrow in Indonesia protected and enlarged the profits of U.S. oil companies, mining companies, plantation owners, and other corporations. As the blood flowed, U.S. media outlets reported that backward Orientals were spontaneously and meaninglessly ending lives they didn't much value (and nobody else should much value either). In reality the primary mover behind the violence and chief instigator in keeping it going and expanding was the U.S. government. The world's third largest communist party was destroyed. The founder of the Third World movement was removed. And an insane right-wing anti-communist regime was established and used as a model for elsewhere.

While we now know from research by Erica Chenoweth that nonviolent campaigns against tyranny and foreign occupation have been far more likely to succeed and those successes dramatically longer lasting than the successes of violent campaigns, knowledge of this approach was impeded by the overthrow of Indonesia. Around the world, a different lesson was “learned,” namely that leftists in Indonesia should have been armed and violent. This lesson brought endless misery to various populations for decades.

Bevins' book is remarkably honest and free of U.S.-centric bias (or anti-U.S. bias for that matter). There is one exception, and it's a predictable one: World War II. According to Bevins, the United States military fought in World War II to lib-

erate prisoners from death camps, and won the war. The power of this mythology in advancing programs of mass killing that Bevins clearly objects to should not be underestimated. The U.S. government before and during World War II refused to evacuate those threatened by the Nazis, declined repeatedly to take any diplomatic or military step to halt that horror, and never associated the war with efforts to save prison camp victims until after the war was over — a war overwhelmingly won by the Soviet Union.

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(Notes from the Editor – continued from inside front cover)

On 4 August the Senate Judiciary subcommittee held a hearing led by Ted Cruz entitled “The Right of the People Peaceably to Assemble: Protecting Speech by Stopping Anarchist Violence.” In the hearing, Ted Cruz accused the BLM founders of being Marxists and of instigating communist violence and the Democrats of avoiding condemnation of Antifa violence. The Democrats condemned all violence by all sides including by white supremacists but would not specifically utter the word Antifa in doing so despite repeated efforts by Cruz. Missing in the hearing was a discussion about how best to respond to the just demands of the protesters and deal with the issues stemming from institutional racism.

Be aware that when politicians insist on peaceful assembly they really have in mind ineffective forms of protest, the kind that are orderly and can be readily and routinely ignored while they go about their merry way with business as usual. Also, be aware that they are not taking a principled stance against violence and looting as such. They never have. How could they? They serve a violent imperial state. None of them adhere to non-violence philosophically. And if they do, they must routinely betray their conviction. Almost all are quite fine with massive state violence visited upon the weak, the vulnerable, the voiceless, the internal colonies of the state, and of course the darker nations in the Global South. They clearly do not care to address the heart of what has animated the streets of this nation with protest, namely, challenging a racist society that refuses to regard blacks as fully human. As they wrangle among themselves about anarchists, Antifa, and riots, blacks and other vulnerable communities are seeing bankruptcies, evictions, disproportionate Covid-19 deaths, and even more extrajudicial killings without any legal recourse.

Indeed, even on the specific issue of looting and rioting they are guilty of double standards. Here is a no doubt inconvenient bit of historical fact that the state would rather assign to the ‘memory hole’ of history: in 2003, as massive riots and looting were wracking Iraq in the aftermath of the criminal U.S. invasion, the then-Secretary of Defense, Donald Rumsfeld, stated that “stuff happens.” He further declared that “freedom’s untidy, and free people are free to make mistakes and commit crimes and do bad things,” and attributed the looting to “pent-up feelings” of oppression and said that it was “part of the price” for the liberation of Iraq. The U.S. occupying Army refused to intervene with the looting and burning down of Iraq’s national Museum and other significant cultural sites; it only protected the interior and oil ministries. Not so in the U.S. Here, the Army and Federal agents are called in to be deployed against the protesters who are frequently called thugs, outside agitators, rioters, looters, anarchists, Antifa, communist-led, and are threatened by Trump with “vicious dogs,” “ominous weapons,” a call to law enforcement to “dominate streets,” and a throwback-to-the-1967-phrase by a southern segregationist sheriff: “When the looting starts, the shooting starts.”

So, it would not be unreasonable to suggest that the ruling elites are rather selective about looting and rioting. They are not driven by matters of principle and conviction. To them, there are good and bad looters, good and bad rioters, just as there are good and bad Muslims.

Serving Wall Street and Empire

The main problem in Washington is not the partisanship that sucks all the oxygen out of the room but the bipartisanship or the consensus about serving Wall Street and empire. To an observer un-schooled about the nature and logic of the political system, it may seem politics and Washington have broken with no hope of extricating either from the abyss they have fallen into. But the truth is that the system works as designed to serve Wall Street and empire above all else.

A [new report](#) shows that U.S. billionaires have added a staggering \$700+ billion to their wealth since the pandemic shutdown began,¹ while \$6.5 trillion in household wealth disappeared and more than 50 million workers lost their jobs. Another report tells us that Jeff Bezos, the owner of Amazon, added [a record \\$13 billion](#) to his net worth in one day, reaching a \$189 billion and staying on track

¹ americansfortaxfairness.org/issue/billionaires-pandemic-wealth-gains-burst-700b/

to become the first trillionaire in the U.S. by 2026.² While the billionaires made their astronomical wealth off of people suffering, the political class squabbles over \$1,200 checks and who qualifies. As of this writing the Democrats and Republicans are stymied on negotiations over the latest coronavirus stimulus bill and fights to revive the lapsed \$600 weekly unemployment benefit through January with Democrats in favor and Republicans wanting to slash it to about \$200. How much more pitiful can this get?

Not forgetting empire, here is what the Democratic nominee, Joe Biden, tweeted in response to a report that President Trump has had second thoughts about his decision to recognize the fascist Juan Guaidó as the legitimate leader of Venezuela and that he is open to meeting with the president Nicolás Maduro: “Trump talks tough on Venezuela, but admires thugs and dictators like Nicolás Maduro. As President, I will stand with the Venezuelan people and for democracy.” Here we have the range of policy differences on an important foreign policy issue between the two sides: it runs from strangling the Venezuelan people and backing an unelected fascist to power to even more enthusiastically strangling the Venezuelan people and backing an unelected fascist to power. Can it get more pathetic than this?

It serves us well to remember that a crucial function of the political system is to ensure a smooth process of accumulation of wealth and power in the hands of corporate capital and the state that serves it, at home and abroad. That’s why the ‘pitiful’ and the ‘pathetic’ are part and parcel of the very DNA of the system. Liberation regarding these matters requires overcoming capitalism and empire.

Another Kind of U.S. Exceptionalism

The one sure way in which the political class in the U.S. is exceptional even in comparison with other ruling classes elsewhere is in its mad resistance to any plans for universal health care. Heck, even Rwanda is working on a national health policy. In the U.S., however, there is scarce any positive or pro-universal health care commentary from anyone that matters in the political class, excepting Senator Sanders and Elizabeth Warren. And that, astonishingly, in the midst of an ongoing pandemic during which millions have lost their jobs and their healthcare, since the latter is often linked to employment, and while the U.S. economy has dropped by 32.9% in the second quarter, the worst plunge on record. You might think the establishment democrats may find this particular moment ripe to demonstrate they care about a most significant concern of their constituency, namely Medicare For All. But just last week the Party’s National Committee panel voted overwhelmingly against an amendment to include Medicare for All as part of its 2020 platform. The DNC panel further rejected an expansion of Medicare to cover children and of dropping the Medicare eligibility from 65 currently to 55.

Remember never to underestimate the subservience of the political class to the tiny sliver of financial oligarchs who control the health “industry” (and much else) in the U.S. and globally. Of course, they refuse a universal health care plan because it would deprive this oligarchy of a massive source of windfall profits while boosting, if you will, the virus of empathy and solidarity among the general population. Long ago the capitalist order identified such sentiments as having deleterious effects on the rule of capital and at the outset of the 20th century established a massive public relations industry dedicated to extricating such sentiments from the hearts and minds of the public. In this, they have not succeeded, as the public by far remains in favor of a universal plan. Instead, what we have is a policy-making process largely insulated from the public and a state captured by the ruling oligarchs.

A Great Unlearning

As Bad as the present dystopian moment is with the advent of coronavirus pandemic, it will compare far more favorably to what is surely coming as a result of climate disruption, unless we act now to prevent it. We’re getting a glimpse of how ill-equipped the profit-above-all-else societies are in dealing with grim scenarios such as a pandemic crisis. Imagine how much exponentially more ill-equipped these same societies are in confronting the nightmarish scenarios of ecological degradation

and climate disruption that they themselves are generating. The latter, unlike the coronavirus, are propelling the planet towards ecocide from which there is no escape. And that’s one crucial difference between the pandemic now and the coming ecocide. Furthermore, unlike the pandemic, there will be no clear guidelines of “social distancing,” “sheltering-at-home,” and wearing of masks, and so on until we defeat the scourge. Ecocide is final; only ruinous chaos rules.

What is required now is a kind of Great Unlearning (in contrast to the oft-repeated hope that maybe this pandemic crisis will be a period of great learning) where millions of people will come to reject long cherished orthodoxies about politics, economics, human nature, and how the world works. Of course, learning from the pandemic too is important, but we must ask: how much valuable learning can take place if our minds remain burdened by the dead weight of dangerous orthodoxies? So, if you find yourself asking “When can we get back to normal?” know that you have suspended your critical faculties. The pre-pandemic era is that which gave us the present moment of a sociopath in the White House, batshit-crazy Republicans, hypocritical establishment Democrats, a dysfunctional politics, racist policing and institutions, a criminally poor public health response to a pandemic, militarism, and an imperial state. We should be asking how we can move forward and build a saner society post-coronavirus?

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² www.businessinsider.com/jeff-bezos-added-13-billion-net-worth-monday-bloomberg-2020-7



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